School Life, Twice Lived

Jinseo Park and Sejin Oh

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Prologue

Sejin Oh

According to estimates published by the U.S. Census Bureau, about two million Koreans are living in America, which makes Korean-Americans the fifth-largest Asian origin population in the U.S. The beginning of this large Korean population currently living in the U.S. can be traced back to 1965, when the Immigration and Nationality Act was passed. In 1965, the United States abolished its original national-origin quota system and introduced new policies prioritising family-based workers and highly skilled workers. This change has led to a dramatic increase in Korean immigration to the U.S: around 25,000 Koreans immigrated per year in the 1970s. Moreover, the demand for immigration to the United States has surged once again in the 2020s, but for a different reason. As more people in South Korea have grown weary of the country's hyper-competitive academic environment and intense private education system, many parents have begun seeking opportunities to educate their children in the United States. At the same time, a large number of individuals have become more interested in immigration for professional reasons, particularly among STEM majors pursuing careers in the U.S. job market. And now, as more Koreans have immigrated to the U.S. for various reasons, they have significantly contributed to the Asian immigrant population and eventually formed Korean communities throughout the country.

My name is Sejin (Sarah) Oh, and I've lived my whole life moving to and from Korea to the US. I've lived in Boulder, Colorado for two years, a year

each in 2nd and 5th grade. I was also born in Ithaca, New York and lived there for a year in 9th grade. Even in Korea, I've switched from attending a foreign language school to an autonomous private school, and thus, currently, I live in a dorm. This change also signified a drastic change from preparing for the Korean college entrance process, including the notorious CSAT, to exploring my options abroad in the US. Therefore, it's safe to say that I have had quite a lot of experience in both countries and both education systems.

One key distinction between the two is the overall atmosphere. Korea is very test-centric, while the US prefers their admissions to be judged on holistic means of measurement.

While I am not part of the statistics, my experience as a Korean now living in the United States has been unique in its own way. My parents had decided to immigrate to the United States because they believed that America offers more opportunities and experiences to students. Right now, living the typical life of an American high school student, I've come to realise that what my parents expected was actually true. Being born in Korea and now living in the US has brought about significant changes in my life and academic career.

Throughout the years, I have come to realise that people outside Korea aren't really aware of what's really going on in its education system. Korea's and the US's education systems are incredibly different, and through this book, we hope to provide you with a clearer distinction between the two. Honestly, there are more differences than similarities, but because both systems have their advantages and disadvantages, it is insightful to see the realities of both, especially if you're a student in either the US or Korea.

Jinseo Park

The experiences that Sejin had, traveling back and forth between South Korea and the United States, closely resonate with my own. Even though the journeys taken by Sejin and I have been distinctly different, we both had to adjust to new schools, as well as determine how education varies in different regions. The connection from my experiences to Sejin's experiences serves as the foundation of this book. My name is Jinseo (Jay) Park, and I am originally from South Korea. However, my education has never been rooted in just "one" country or system. I have lived and studied in Korea, Malaysia, and the US. Different phases of my childhood have been spent in international schools influenced by American and British systems and then returning to Korea amidst the COVID-19 pandemic, attending the Korean public school and autonomous private high School. Each transition required a concomitant shift in learning not only curricula but also language, culture, and the understanding of success and achievement as a student.

When I first went to school in Malaysia, I barely spoke any English, and struggled to make friends and communicate. I didn't pass my first English placement test and had to attend additional classes. As I slowly started to adapt to the language and culture, my grades began to improve. I learned that sometimes, a student's overall grade doesn't represent their true understanding and ability in the educational system, especially if they're still new to the environment.

During the COVID-19 pandemic, my family and I moved back to Korea, and I attended a public girls' middle school and Daewon Foreign Language High School. The way Korea approaches education is extremely different

from what I've previously experienced at international schools. Korean education is stricter and centers around test scores and college readiness, compared to opportunities and personal growth in other school systems I've been a part of. At the same time, I've also learned to understand the burden and expectation placed on students in Korea. Knowing that I had always dreamt of going back to studying abroad, I decided to attend a foreign language high school, not knowing that another chance would come by again.

My sophomore year, in December 2024, my family and I permanently immigrated to the U.S. At first, it was strange being in an American high school where students switched classrooms and took a more hands-on approach to choosing what classes they wanted to take as well as what extracurricular activities they were interested in. As I gradually started to adjust to my new environment, I began to cherish the opportunities that the American education system gave which helped me to discover my interests and hidden talents I never knew I had, outside of my standardized test scores and overall GPA.

Through these various educational systems, I've learned that both Korean and American education systems have their strengths and weaknesses, and they are both equally outstanding in different contexts. While they both put a significant amount of expectations on students and the overall importance of succeeding in academics, I learned so much from both of my educational journeys, and that's how Sejin and I hope to spread our message through this book. We hope to not only break down the stereotypes but also shed light on the impact of education and the opportunities it provides for students in both systems, not just focusing on the surface level, rather than looking at the underlying factors and contexts.

History (US)

Education Before European Colonization

History studies of American education usually focus on the education systems that existed after the Europeans came to settle in America, without paying any attention to the native Americans who already had settled there. The reason for that might be that "education" is associated with classes and school rooms and textbooks, as most of modern education occurs in such places. But the absence of schools and classes does not mean the absence of education either. Long before colonization started in America, various indigenous communities used to educate their young generation in their own special way.[1]

The term “education” refers to the purposeful process of acquiring and sharing knowledge, developing skills, and shaping values.[2] Indigenous nations taught their children and younger generations through stories that contained cultural heritage including history, values, moral lessons, and community experiences; by allowing children to observe what adults did; by teaching them the skills and techniques needed to survive; and by integrating them into community activities and services. More than just memorizing information, these kinds of learning were applied in real life and created a

[1] UNESCO, “Education,” accessed August 3, 2026, https://www.unesco.org/en/query-list/e/education.
[2] UNESCO, “Education,” accessed August 3, 2026, https://www.unesco.org/en/query-list/e/education.

sense of responsibility because through these experiences children learned their roles and responsibilities within the community.[3]
Education becomes involved in the process of cultural conservation through the transmission of the language, history, and values to the next generations of the indigenous nations. Nonetheless, as soon as European colonizers started coming to North America and occupying this territory, colonialists and then federal authorities began forcing the indigenous nations' children to attend schools that were based on the education in European languages and values as a way of suppression of Indigenous cultures, which they considered valueless.[4] Thus, this shows that not only is education a way of transmission of neutral information, but also a tool of influencing cultural preservation. The next part will be dedicated to the educational system introduced by Europeans settlers and their values and intentions behind its creation.

Colonial Education and Regional Differences

In the early colonial period, there was no unified education system established in America. Each colony had different education systems and goals, but the Puritans in New England placed greater importance on

[3] Smithsonian National Museum of the American Indian, "Celebrating Native Cultures Through Words: Storytelling and Oral Traditions," May 18, 2021, https://americanindian.si.edu/nk360/informational/storytelling-and-oral-traditions; Alberta Yeboah, "Education among Native Americans in the Periods Before and After Contact with Europeans: An Overview" (paper presented at the Annual National Association of Native American Studies Conference, Houston, Texas, February 14–19, 2005), 5–6,https://www.ed.gov/media/document/yeboah200502pdf-5241.pdf.

[4] U.S. Department of the Interior, "Secretary Haaland Announces Federal Indian Boarding School Initiative," June 22, 2021, https://www.doi.gov/pressreleases/secretary-haaland-announces-federal-indian-boarding-school-initiative .

literacy than people in other colonies did.[5] They believed that to truly understand faith, individuals should read the Bible by themselves instead of overly relying on the sermons from the preachers. So they thought that ignorance puts not only individuals but the entire religious community at risk.[6] Since they emphasized educating individuals to read the Bible, education took place in various settings that involved many people, such as homes, churches, and dame schools.[7] This again shows that unlike modern education that prioritizes individual growth, career development, and social engagement, Puritan education focused more on upholding faith and a sense of community.

One of the most representative examples of Puritan educational philosophy manifesting in actual law is the Old Deluder Satan Act of 1647. While Massachusetts, a colony in New England, had already made parents responsible for their children's reading education as early as 1642, the law of 1647 extended that responsibility to the town community.[8] The reason why there is "Satan" in its name is because Puritans believed that ignorance hindered people's understanding of the Bible. This act was significant because under this law, towns with 50 or more families were required to hire a teacher to instruct students in reading and writing, and towns with 100 or more families were required to operate a grammar school to prepare male students for Harvard College. Also, this law has great significance for the

[5] Nancy Kober and Diane Stark Rentner, *History and Evolution of Public Education in the US* (Washington, DC: Center on Education Policy, 2020), 1–2,https://files.eric.ed.gov/fulltext/ED606970.pdf.

[6] David Carleton, "Old Deluder Satan Act of 1647 (1647)," *The First Amendment Encyclopedia*, January 1, 2009, last updated July 2, 2024, https://firstamendment.mtsu.edu/article/old-deluder-satan-act-of-1647/.

[7] Kober and Rentner, *History and Evolution of Public Education in the US*, 1.

[8] Carleton, "Old Deluder Satan Act of 1647."

development of the American education system since this law recognized education not merely as a family matter, but as a responsibility enforced by the Massachusetts colonial government and carried out by local towns.[9]

However, this law did not offer free, universal public education like modern public education today. The extent to which the law was enforced varied from town to town, and families sometimes had to bear the cost of the teacher's wages.[10] Although some girls and children from poor families received basic reading instruction, they did not have the same access to advanced education as boys or children from wealthy families. In particular, advanced education—such as grammar school and university preparation—was concentrated among wealthy white male students.[11] This shows that education centered on Puritan beliefs may have made it difficult for children to encounter diverse religions and perspectives. Also, this might illustrate the inequality and discrimination that existed in this period since not everyone received the same opportunities to be educated, and the level of education differed depending on their sex or social class. Thus, the expansion of education and discrimination have coexisted since the early development of colonial public schooling, and these developments demonstrate that these disparities based on region and social class would continue to appear throughout the later history of American education.
In the Middle Colonies, there were New York, New Jersey, Pennsylvania, and Delaware. In this region, a variety of religious and ethnic groups including Quakers, Dutch Reformed, Lutherans, Anglicans, and Jews lived

[9] Carleton, "Old Deluder Satan Act of 1647."

[10] Massachusetts Teachers Association, "Schools Took Root Early in Mass.," accessed August 4, 2026,https://www.massteacher.org/Founding-of-the-MTA; Alyssa Kariofyllis, "Women's Opportunities for Education Along the Battle Road," *National Park Service*, last updated October 20, 2021, https://www.nps.gov/articles/000/alyssa-kariofyllis-women-of-the-battle-road-paper-3.htm.

[11] Kariofyllis, "Women's Opportunities for Education Along the Battle Road."

together. So unlike in New England, where the Puritans had a strong influence, it was difficult for a single religion or educational approach to dominate the entire region.[12] So there existed various forms of education, such as church schools, private schools, tuition schools, charity schools, home education, and apprenticeships.[13] However, educational diversity did not equate to educational equality. As in New England, children from poor families or rural areas faced difficulties in obtaining an education due to cost and distance.[14] Furthermore, while the coexistence of diverse religious and ethnic groups in the same region may have exposed people to broader perspectives, the lack of a unified system likely widened disparities in educational opportunities and may have actually served to reinforce the distinctions between these various ethnic groups and communities.

In the Southern Colonies, there were Maryland, Virginia, North Carolina, South Carolina, and Georgia. In these colonies, it was hard to establish village-centered schools like those in New England because farms and residences were widely scattered. So wealthy plantation owners often hired private tutors or sent their sons to other colonies or to England for their education. In contrast, poor or rural white children relied on small local schools, charity schools, and apprenticeships, or sometimes received no formal education at all. Also, while some girls received basic instruction in reading and religion, the opportunities for higher education were generally

[12] Patricia U. Bonomi, "Religious Pluralism in the Middle Colonies," *Divining America*, National Humanities Center, accessed August 4, 2026, https://nationalhumanitiescenter.org/tserve/eighteen/ekeyinfo/midcol.htm

[13] Nancy Kober and Diane Stark Rentner, *History and Evolution of Public Education in the US* (Washington, DC: Center on Education Policy, George Washington University, 2020), 1, https://files.eric.ed.gov/fulltext/ED606970.pdf.

[14] Kober and Rentner, *History and Evolution of Public Education*, 1–2.

more limited for girls than for boys as in the New England colonies.[15] However, the situation was even worse for enslaved and free Black children. Although the education of these individuals was not completely prohibited by law across the South during the colonial era, enslaved and free Black children faced severe barriers to education, leaving many of them without even a basic education.[16] Even though the Williamsburg Bray School taught hundreds of enslaved and free Black children reading and religion from 1760 to 1774, its educational purposes also included promoting Christian obedience and maintaining the order of slavery.[17] This case illustrates that while education offers opportunities to acquire knowledge and literacy, it can also serve as a means of control to maintain existing class and racial hierarchies.

As discussed earlier, there were clear similarities and differences that existed in these three different regions. In New England, schools developed with a focus on religious literacy and community responsibility. Yet, in the Middle Colonies, various groups operated different educational institutions due to religious and ethnic diversity. In the South, due to widely dispersed settlement patterns and an agrarian economy, education relied primarily on the home and private tutors, which differed from education in both New England and the Middle Colonies. In this way, early American education was not a nationally unified system but was instead shaped by the religious,

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[15] Linda H. Rowe, *A History of Black Education and Bruton Heights School, Williamsburg, Virginia*, Colonial Williamsburg Foundation Library Research Report Series 0373 (Williamsburg, VA: Colonial Williamsburg Foundation, 1997), 6–7, https://research.colonialwilliamsburg.org/DigitalLibrary/view/index.cfm?doc=ResearchReports%5CRR0373.xml.

[16] Rowe, *A History of Black Education*, 3–7.

[17] Colonial Williamsburg Foundation, "'This Was the Bray School,'" *Trend & Tradition*, Summer 2021, https://www.colonialwilliamsburg.org/discover/resource-hub/trend-tradition-magazine/trend-tradition-summer-2021/this-was-the-bray-school/.

economic, geographic, and labor systems of each region. While these regional differences laid the groundwork for the importance of local autonomy in American education, they also created a situation where educational opportunities varied based on a child's place of residence, gender, race, and wealth.[18] So again, this shows that in American education, local autonomy and educational inequality can be seen as having developed together from the very beginning. However, following the American Revolution, the purpose of education expanded beyond maintaining religion to include cultivating citizens of the republic, which will be discussed more deeply in the next section.[19]

Education in the Early Republic

Following the American Revolution, the United States transformed from a group of colonies ruled by the British monarchy into a republic driven by citizen participation; leaders believed that for self-government to succeed, citizens needed to understand political and social issues and be capable of monitoring those in power. So even though the religious purpose of education did not disappear, the objective of fostering citizens' knowledge, morality, and civic virtue was added.[20] One of the leaders who believed that citizens should be more educated about political and social issues was Thomas Jefferson, who argued that educated citizens could prevent the

[18] Kober and Rentner, *History and Evolution of Public Education*, 1, 7.

[19] Kober and Rentner, *History and Evolution of Public Education*, 2; Thomas Jefferson Foundation, "The Role of Education," *Monticello*, accessed August 4, 2026, https://www.monticello.org/the-art-of-citizenship/the-role-of-education.

[20] Nancy Kober and Diane Stark Rentner, *History and Evolution of Public Education in the US* (Washington, DC: Center on Education Policy, George Washington University, 2020), 2, https://files.eric.ed.gov/fulltext/ED606970.pdf.

corruption of power and tyranny. He proposed the "Bill for the More General Diffusion of Knowledge" in the late 1770s, aiming to educate capable children at public expense, regardless of their wealth or family background. However, the Virginia legislature did not pass the bill when it was presented in 1778 and 1780 and it's likely because there were people who opposed the associated costs and the role of the government even though they agreed with the necessity of public education.[21] Aside from this, Noah Webster also sought to shape a national identity distinct from Britain by standardizing American spelling and pronunciation through textbooks.[22] This shows that education was becoming a means of shaping citizens and the shared identity required for the new nation, going beyond merely imparting knowledge to individuals.

As noted above, leaders like Jefferson had proposed public education, but there was not yet a unified school system nationwide during the Early Republic. Nonetheless, there were efforts to support public education such as the "Land Ordinance of 1785", under which Section 16 was set aside to support schools in each township of the western region.[23] Also, there was another law named "Northwest Ordinance of 1787" that promoted schools and education, with a belief that knowledge is essential for good government and society.[24] So this signifies that the national government began to recognize education as a public responsibility, but still, the Constitution did

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[21] Anna Berkes, "A Bill for the More General Diffusion of Knowledge," *Thomas Jefferson Encyclopedia*, Monticello, April 2009, accessed August 4, 2026, https://www.monticello.org/encyclopedia/bill-more-general-diffusion-knowledge.

[22] Library of Congress, "Books That Shaped America: 1750 to 1800," section "Noah Webster, *A Grammatical Institute of the English Language* (1783)," accessed August 4, 2026, https://www.loc.gov/exhibits/books-that-shaped-america/1750-to-1800.html.

[23] National Archives, "Guide to Senate Records: Chapter 12," sec. 12.13, accessed August 4, 2026, https://www.archives.gov/legislative/guide/senate/chapter-12.htm.

[24] National Archives, "Northwest Ordinance (1787)," accessed August 4, 2026,https://www.archives.gov/milestone-documents/northwest-ordinance.

not stipulate direct federal authority over education. Subsequently, the establishment, financing, and operation of schools still relied heavily on state governments and local communities.[25] Meanwhile, the concept of "Republican Motherhood" also expanded educational opportunities for some white women, as it was believed that women should educate their sons—the exemplary citizens of the future. But this expansion was not really intended to recognize women as citizens equal to men, but rather to enable them to better fulfill their roles as wives and mothers.[26] Also, since the concept of "citizen" mainly focused on white males, many enslaved and free Black people and Indigenous people still couldn't receive equal educational opportunities.[27] So even though the new nation emphasized that education was essential to democracy, the right to education itself was not yet democratic in practice. This gap between ideals and reality helped create demand for the Common School Movement in the 19th century, which called for a more systematic and extensive school system.[28]

The Common School Movement

Despite the efforts of Early Republic leaders to promote public education, free public education had not become widely established across the United States by the 1830s. Against this backdrop, a more systematic educational system became necessary due to industrialization, urban growth, rising immigration, and regional disparities among existing schools. Consequently, efforts to expand public education grew increasingly common. One

[25] Kober and Rentner, *History and Evolution of Public Education*, 2, 7.

[26] Johanna Neuman, "The Prequel: Women's Suffrage Before 1848," National Park Service, last updated September 11, 2025,https://www.archives.gov/milestone-documents/northwest-ordinance.

[27] Kober and Rentner, *History and Evolution of Public Education*, 1–2.

[28] Kober and Rentner, *History and Evolution of Public Education*, 3.

movement that took place during this period was the Common School Movement, which aimed at establishing public schools funded by taxes and where all children could study together irrespective of their social classes.[29] The state of Massachusetts formed a State Board of Education in 1837, appointing Horace Mann as the secretary of this board. Mann argued that there should be free public schooling, publicly funded schooling, a common curriculum, good school buildings and proper teacher training, as students ought to learn not only academics but also virtues.[30] Finally, in 1839, the first public teacher-training institution in the United States—a "normal school"—was established in Lexington.[31] Proponents believed that public education could mold children into literate, moral, and productive citizens while also reducing poverty and crime.[32] These developments show that education was beginning to transition from a benefit dependent on a family's means or charity into a public institution requiring investment by society as a whole.

Even though the Common School Movement proposed universal education, the term "universal" did not include all children equally in practice. Some citizens opposed paying taxes for the education of other families' children, and some wealthy families preferred private schools. Another problem was that even though common schools were said to be non-sectarian, the Bible studies and values taught were actually of a Protestant nature, which brought conflict with the Catholic immigrants.

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[29] Nancy Kober and Diane Stark Rentner, *History and Evolution of Public Education in the US* (Washington, DC: Center on Education Policy, George Washington University, 2020), 2–3, https://files.eric.ed.gov/fulltext/ED606970.pdf.

[30] Massachusetts Historical Society, "Horace Mann Collection, 1669–1926," collection guide, accessed August 4, 2026, https://www.masshist.org/collection-guides/view/fa0234; Kober and Rentner, *History and Evolution of Public Education*, 3.

[31] Framingham State University, "Framingham State History," accessed August 4, 2026, https://www.framingham.edu/about-fsu/framingham-state-history.

[32] Kober and Rentner, *History and Evolution of Public Education*, 3.

Moreover, in many areas, the Black children had separate schools or were not provided with public education at all.[33] As a specific example, young Sarah Roberts was denied admission to a nearby school for white students, and her experience became the basis of a significant court case. In *Roberts v. City of Boston* (1850), the Massachusetts court upheld the practice of segregated schools; however, following persistent resistance from the Black community, Massachusetts banned racial segregation in public schools in 1855.[34] And while opportunities for girls' elementary education increased during this period, the curriculum and opportunities for secondary and higher education remained more limited than those available to boys. Also, public schools spread more rapidly in cities and the Northeast, while developing much more slowly in rural areas and the South, partly because settlements were more widely dispersed in the South.[35] While the development of "common schools" significantly expanded educational opportunities, it simultaneously promoted particular religious, moral, and American values as the "common standard."[36] Thus, this movement can be viewed as both a step toward educational equality and the beginning of a new conflict over who was to be included in that equality. Furthermore, in the period

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[33] Kober and Rentner, *History and Evolution of Public Education*, 3, 5; Graham Warder, "Horace Mann and the Creation of the Common School," *Social Welfare History Project*, Virginia Commonwealth University Libraries, accessed August 4, 2026, https://socialwelfare.library.vcu.edu/programs/education/horace-mann-creation-common-school/.

[34] Commonwealth of Massachusetts, "Roberts v. The City of Boston, 1849," Commonwealth Museum, accessed August 4, 2026, https://www.sec.state.ma.us/divisions/commonwealth-museum/exhibits/online/freedoms-agenda/freedoms-agenda-8.htm; National Park Service, "The Sarah Roberts Case," May 29, 2024, https://www.nps.gov/articles/the-sarah-roberts-case.htm.

[35] Kober and Rentner, *History and Evolution of Public Education*, 4, 6.

[36] Warder, "Horace Mann and the Creation of the Common School"; Kober and Rentner, *History and Evolution of Public Education*, 5.

following the Civil War, education became a crucial means for newly freed Black people to secure civil rights and independence.[37]

Education During Reconstruction and Jim Crow

Before the Civil War, many Southern states banned teaching enslaved people to read and write or imposed strong limitations on such education.[38] So after slavery was abolished in 1865, education became not only a source of knowledge, but a means to actually exercise freedom, independence, and citizenship. Many newly freed Black people established schools themselves using churches, homes, and existing buildings, and secured teachers and funding for education, not solely waiting for government assistance.[39] In 1865, Congress established the "Freedmen's Bureau" and provided food, medical, and legal support, as well as educational assistance. Rather than directly operating every school itself, the Bureau provided support—such as buildings, teachers, and instructional materials—to enable Black communities as well as religious and charitable organizations to establish schools. Black and white teachers instructed not only children but also adults who had been denied an education due to slavery.[40] By 1870, the

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[37] Kober and Rentner, *History and Evolution of Public Education*, 5.

[38] Nancy Kober and Diane Stark Rentner, *History and Evolution of Public Education in the US* (Washington, DC: Center on Education Policy, George Washington University, 2020), 5, https://files.eric.ed.gov/fulltext/ED606970.pdf.

[39] National Park Service, "African Americans and Education During Reconstruction: The Tolson's Chapel Schools," August 8, 2023, https://www.nps.gov/articles/african-americans-and-education-during-reconstruction-the-tolsons-chapel-schools.htm

[40] National Archives, "The Freedmen's Bureau," last reviewed October 28, 2021, https://www.archives.gov/research/african-americans/freedmens-bureau; Library of Congress, "The Freedmen," accessed August 4, 2026, https://www.loc.gov/classroom-materials/united-states-history-primary-source-timeline/civil-war-and-reconstruction-1861-1877/freedmen/.

Freedmen's Bureau had supported more than 1,500 schools and over 100,000 students.[41] Then, during the Reconstruction era, the newly drafted constitutions of Southern states began to mandate free public education for both Black and white children. Nevertheless, from the outset, Black and white children were largely educated in separate schools.[42] Viewed in this light, education for emancipated Black people was not merely a process of social adaptation, but a means of reclaiming the human autonomy and citizenship rights that had been denied to them under slavery.

But this rapid growth of Black education created a strong backlash from some white people who believed that educated Black individuals could threaten the existing racial and economic order. Due to this, Black schools and teachers faced threats and violence, and school buildings were even attacked or burned down.[43] But the situation got even worse when the white supremacist forces regained control of Southern state governments after Reconstruction ended around 1877, and Jim Crow laws and customs enforced racial segregation in public facilities, including schools. While schools for Black students also existed as public schools, they were severely disadvantaged compared to schools for white students in terms of funding, facilities, textbooks, the length of the school term, and teacher salaries.[44] Furthermore, "Plessy v. Ferguson (1896)" was initiated due to a conflict with the Separate Car Act of Louisiana regarding racial segregation on trains. On the other hand, the Supreme Court introduced the "separate but equal" rule,

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[41] National Park Service, "The Rise and Fall of the Freedmen's Bureau," https://www.nps.gov/articles/000/the-rise-and-fall-of-the-freedmen-s-bureau.htm.

[42] Kober and Rentner, *History and Evolution of Public Education*, 5.

[43] National Museum of African American History and Culture, "The Freedmen's Bureau: New Beginnings for Recently Freed," accessed August 4, 2026, https://nmaahc.si.edu/explore/stories/freedmens-bureau-new-beginnings-recently-freed.

[44] Kober and Rentner, *History and Evolution of Public Education*, 5; Library of Congress, "The Civil Rights Act of 1964: A Long Struggle for Freedom—Prologue," accessed August 4, 2026, https://www.loc.gov/exhibits/civil-rights-act/prologue.html.

which later became the legal foundation of segregation in almost all spheres, including schools.[45] Despite the fact that the segregated Black schools were anything but equal, this idea remained valid in the sphere of education until the decision made in the "Brown v. Board of Education" case in 1954.[46] Nevertheless, the Black people continued struggling for their independence and progress through education; they set up schools, trained teachers, and organized fundraising campaigns to pay for education.[47] Thus, even though Reconstruction provided more legal opportunities for education, Jim Crow introduced new ways to discriminate based on the unfair distribution of educational opportunities and quality. Apart from this, while Black people strived to gain their freedom through education, Indigenous children were being forcefully assimilated through education.[48]

Indigenous Boarding Schools and Forced Assimilation

As discussed in the previous section, education was used as a method to gain freedom for Black people. However, during the same time period, education was used to strip Indigenous children of their cultures. In 1819, the Civilization Fund Act was passed, which marked the beginning of federal financial support for Indigenous education provided by missionary

[45] National Archives, "Plessy v. Ferguson (1896)," last reviewed February 8, 2022, https://www.archives.gov/milestone-documents/plessy-v-ferguson.
[46] National Archives, "Brown v. Board of Education (1954)," last reviewed March 18, 2024, https://www.archives.gov/milestone-documents/brown-v-board-of-education.
[47] National Park Service, "Reconstruction Era African American Schools in the South," June 27, 2024, https://www.nps.gov/articles/reconstruction-era-african-american-schools-in-the-south.htm.
[48] U.S. Department of the Interior, "Secretary Haaland Announces Federal Indian Boarding School Initiative," June 22, 2021, https://www.doi.gov/pressreleases/secretary-haaland-announces-federal-indian-boarding-school-initiative

organizations.[49] Nonetheless, the true motive behind the education of these indigenous children was to assimilate them into white American culture, which would force them to leave behind their tribal language, religion, and culture. This idea became more systematic and wide-scale after the Civil War. An example of such an off-reservation boarding school would be that of the Carlisle Indian Industrial School, set up by Richard Henry Pratt in 1879 in Pennsylvania.[50] These children were sent away to schools far from their homes and communities, where they were compelled to take on English names, get their hair cut, give up their clothes, and speak the English language only.[51] So the real purpose of establishing this school was not to teach new knowledge to Indigenous children, but to erase their existing identities and replace them with new ones. Besides English classes, children had to study Christianity, receive military-style discipline, do some hard work, and gain vocational skills. Moreover, children that violated the rules and spoke their own language could be punished.[52] What is more, a lot of children died because of poor nutrition and lack of medical assistance, diseases, and physical and psychological abuse.[53] In 2024, the investigation

[49] Bryan Newland, *Federal Indian Boarding School Initiative Investigative Report*, vol. 2 (Washington, DC: U.S. Department of the Interior, July 2024), 18, https://www.bia.gov/sites/default/files/media_document/doi_federal_indian_boarding_school_initiative_investigative_report_vii_final_508_compliant.pdf.

[50] National Park Service, "History & Culture: Carlisle Federal Indian Boarding School National Monument," last updated December 9, 2024, https://www.nps.gov/cibs/learn/historyculture/index.htm.

[51] National Park Service, "History & Culture: Carlisle Federal Indian Boarding School National Monument."

[52] National Museum of the American Indian, "Chapter 3: Boarding Schools," *Native Words, Native Warriors*, Smithsonian Institution, accessed August 4, 2026, https://americanindian.si.edu/nk360/code-talkers/boarding-schools/.

[53] National Park Service, "The Carlisle Indian Industrial School: Assimilation with Education after the Indian Wars," last updated December 16, 2024, https://www.nps.gov/articles/the-carlisle-indian-industrial-school-assimilation-with-education-after-the-indian-wars-teaching-with-historic-places.htm.

carried out by the U.S. Department of the Interior found 417 federally funded Indigenous boarding schools in 37 states or territories that existed from 1819 to 1969. At least 973 children died at those boarding schools, however, the real number is likely to be higher.[54] The research gives an idea of the extent of the harm done to the Indigenous children, it shows how this policy disrupted the intergenerational transfer of language and culture, leaving serious wounds in families and communities.[55] Nevertheless, it does not mean that the Indigenous people were passive victims. They resisted this policy and the school system, trying to preserve their languages and traditions.[56] Yet, the fact that education was abused as a tool to limit the freedom and identity of Indigenous people while it was used as a means to secure freedom for Black people does not change.

Industrialization, Immigration, and Progressive Education

From the late 19th century onwards, rapid industrialization and urbanization caused many people to move to cities. In addition to that, the large number of immigrants, including European immigrants, resulted in an increase in the number of children and the need for schools.[57] However, because the industrial society needed literate workers who knew how to follow schedules and rules, state governments expanded compulsory schooling laws partly in response to these social and economic changes. By

[54] Newland, *Federal Indian Boarding School Initiative Investigative Report*, 6, 93.

[55] Newland, *Federal Indian Boarding School Initiative Investigative Report*, 95–96.

[56] National Museum of the American Indian, "Chapter 3: Boarding Schools"; National Park Service, "The Carlisle Indian Industrial School."

[57] Library of Congress, "America at School," *America at Work, America at Leisure: Motion Pictures from 1894 to 1915*, accessed August 4, 2026, https://www.loc.gov/collections/america-at-work-and-leisure-1894-to-1915/articles-and-essays/america-at-school/.

1918, all states adopted compulsory schooling laws, but the age range and extent of enforcement differed from one place to another in the early days.[58] As compulsory education expanded, schools increasingly grouped students into grade levels based on age, and school operations—such as common timetables, fixed class durations, and curricula—became increasingly standardized.[59] Additionally, public schools participated in the Americanization of immigrant children by teaching English, American history, civics, and American social norms. Also, many schools emphasized American history and civic values in their instruction of immigrant children, which did help children adapt to a new society, but could result in the language and culture used at home being treated as inferior.[60] Thus, in short, while compulsory schooling provided educational opportunities for children, it also involved forcing immigrants to give up their languages and cultures in favor of common American standards, which could be considered a form of forced assimilation. Requiring more children to attend school represents an expansion of equality, but requiring them all to adopt the same language and culture as occurred during this period could amount to yet another form of pressure to assimilate.

As the tremendous growth in schools became visible, criticism arose about too much attention paid to rote learning, discipline and standardization of teaching. Progressive educators criticized this type of education system, because many of them thought that children should learn through experience and activities, not through rote learning of facts. One of these

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[58] Michael S. Katz, *A History of Compulsory Education Laws* (Bloomington, IN: Phi Delta Kappa Educational Foundation, 1976), 5–6, 20–21, https://files.eric.ed.gov/fulltext/ED119389.pdf.

[59] National Park Service, "Quincy Grammar School," last updated November 2, 2020, https://www.nps.gov/places/quincy-grammar-school.htm; Katz, *A History of Compulsory Education Laws*, 20–21.

[60] Victoria-María MacDonald, "American Latino Theme Study: Education," National Park Service, last updated July 10, 2020, https://www.nps.gov/articles/latinothemeeducation.htm.

progressive educators was John Dewey, who founded the University of Chicago Laboratory Schools in 1896, thus testing his educational theory in practice.[61] According to Dewey, schools should not be just places of transferring knowledge or training workers, but places where students participate in community life and become democratic citizens. So in this school children learned through problem-solving, cooperation and practical work, by participating in hands-on activities such as gardening, cooking, sewing, and carpentry, which showed Dewey's effort to avoid separating the knowledge acquired at school from real life.[62] But progressive education was not applied everywhere and to all students – traditional instruction based on rote learning and a teacher-centered approach existed as well. At this time, education aimed at producing disciplined workers required by society and education aimed at developing independent citizens developed together.

Brown v. Board and the Struggle for School Integration

In the middle of the 20th century, the segregation of blacks from whites in schools continued despite the development of public education and progressive education. As mentioned above, the notion of "separate but equal" that was stated in the decision in Plessy v. Ferguson provided the justification of segregation of schools. Black schools continued having worse conditions, worse equipment and lesser funding. However, as the discrimination continued—including the case of Linda Brown, a Black girl, not being allowed to attend a white school nearby—black people and the

[61] University of Chicago Laboratory Schools, "Our History," accessed August 4, 2026, https://www.ucls.uchicago.edu/about-lab/history.

[62] John Dewey, *The School and Society* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1900), Project Gutenberg, https://www.gutenberg.org/files/53910/53910-h/53910-h.htm; University of Chicago Laboratory Schools, "Our History."

NAACP continued to fight against the discrimination in courts. With increasing concerns about racial discrimination in education, the US Supreme Court made a unanimous decision in the case of *Brown v. Board of Education* on May 17, 1954. The Court concluded that racial segregation in public schools contradicted the Equal Protection Clause of the Fourteenth Amendment and announced that "separate educational facilities are inherently unequal."[63] Although this decision ended the possibility of legally justifying segregation in public schools, it is important to recognize the difference between prohibiting discrimination and establishing real equality, as the next section will show.

However, the ruling in the Brown case did not put an end to the practice of segregation in the public education system instantly. With regard to the *Brown II* case in 1955, the Supreme Court required schools to desegregate "with all deliberate speed." Since this phrase was quite vague and did not imply any particular time limits, many Southern states as well as their local school districts used this opportunity to postpone the process of desegregation.[64] One of the most common examples of such behavior was the event that occurred in 1957, when nine African-American students attempted to enter Central High School in Little Rock, Arkansas. Governor Orval Faubus deployed the Arkansas National Guard in order to prevent the students from entering the high school. Then, Eisenhower federalized the National Guard and ordered the soldiers from the 101st Airborne Division to protect the students.[65] Eventually, the Civil Rights Act of 1964 provided

[63] National Archives, "Brown v. Board of Education (1954)," https://www.archives.gov/milestone-documents/brown-v-board-of-education.

[64] National Archives, "Brown v. Board of Education: Timeline," https://www.archives.gov/education/lessons/brown-v-board/timeline.html.

[65] Dwight D. Eisenhower Presidential Library, "Civil Rights: The Little Rock School Integration Crisis," https://www.eisenhowerlibrary.gov/research/online-documents/civil-rights-little-rock-school-integration-crisis.

the federal government with the ability to file lawsuits against schools for segregation and to deny them federal funding.[66] Nonetheless, despite the fact that these measures led to certain results with regard to the decrease in legally enforced segregation, these measures did not eliminate educational inequalities. Therefore, the history following the Brown decision shows that changing the law can create an important opportunity for equality, but legal change alone cannot immediately establish equal education in practice.

The Expanding Federal Role in Modern Education

Through the Brown decision and the civil rights movement, the U.S. federal government began to show an attitude that educational equality could no longer be left solely to state governments and local communities. One example in which this change appeared most clearly was the 1965 Elementary and Secondary Education Act, which President Lyndon B. Johnson promoted as part of his War on Poverty. This law established the foundation for the federal government to provide substantial funding for public elementary and secondary education, and through Title I in particular provided additional funds to schools and school districts attended by many low-income students.[67] This was important in that it marked an expansion of the federal government's effort to view the issue of varying education quality depending on students' home environments and residential areas as a public problem that the federal government should address. However, this law did not integrate schools across the country into

[66] U.S. Department of Justice, "Types of Educational Opportunities Discrimination," https://www.justice.gov/crt/types-educational-opportunities-discrimination; U.S. Department of Justice, "Title VI of the Civil Rights Act of 1964," https://www.justice.gov/crt/fcs/TitleVI.
[67] National Center for Education Statistics, "Introduction: Title I of the Elementary and Secondary Education Act," https://nces.ed.gov/pubs2019/titlei/intro.asp.

a single federal system of education. Because primary authority over school administration and the curriculum still remained with state governments and local school districts, American education maintained both federal support and local autonomy at the same time. Later, the federal government also enacted other laws to expand educational opportunities. Title IX, passed in 1972, banned discrimination on the basis of sex in any federally funded educational program. In other words, women and girls gained greater protection against discrimination in classes, school activities, and sports.[68] Also, the Education for All Handicapped Children Act, passed in 1975, stated that children with disabilities should have access to a free appropriate public education, and later, in 1990, it was renamed the Individuals with Disabilities Education Act.[69] From the above information, we can conclude that the right to education is no longer just the right to go to school, but it includes the right to participate in the educational process. At the same time, the federal government, without directly operating schools, began creating nationwide standards for educational opportunity by using financial aid and civil rights legislation.

However, in the 1980s, interest in American education began to shift from expanding opportunities for access to schools to examining what students are actually learning. The federal report A Nation at Risk, published in 1983, warned that low academic achievement and educational levels in American schools could threaten the nation's economic strength and international competitiveness.[70] Afterward, states began placing greater emphasis on academic standards and standardized testing, and the idea that

[68] U.S. Department of Education, "Title IX and Sex Discrimination," https://www.ed.gov/laws-and-policy/civil-rights-laws/title-ix-and-sex-discrimination.

[69] U.S. Department of Education, "A History of the Individuals with Disabilities Education Act," https://sites.ed.gov/idea/IDEA-History/.

[70] National Commission on Excellence in Education, *A Nation at Risk: The Imperative for Educational Reform* (1983), https://files.eric.ed.gov/fulltext/ED226006.pdf.

schools and teachers should be held accountable for students' test results also grew stronger. This trend became even more evident in the No Child Left Behind Act enacted in 2002. This law required public school students to take reading and math tests annually in grades 3 through 8 and once in high school, and it required test results to be reported separately by race, economic disadvantage, disability status, and other group characteristics.[71] Consequently, it ensured that any disparities in achievement among the various groups of students could be seen through this method as opposed to using the average of the overall performance, and it ensured that the schools were answerable for the success of all the students. However, critics argued that teachers tended to focus too much on the material tested in the examinations, thereby neglecting the arts and social studies classes. It was also pointed out that the system fails to adequately take into account existing educational inequality, as schools with many students in disadvantaged circumstances face harsher punishment for lower test results.[72] Ultimately, in 2015, the Every Student Succeeds Act replaced No Child Left Behind, and while maintaining standardized testing and the disclosure of student subgroup results, it returned more authority to state governments to determine school assessment and methods of improvement.[73] Thus, the history of modern American education has continuously oscillated between efforts to apply common standards to all students and efforts to preserve regional autonomy. Although most children today have access to public education, there are still differences in school

[71] U.S. Department of Education, *No Child Left Behind: A Desktop Reference* (2002), https://www.ed.gov/media/document/no-child-left-behind-desktop-reference-archived-2002-98652.pdf.
[72] U.S. Senate Committee on Health, Education, Labor, and Pensions, *Fixing No Child Left Behind: Testing and Accountability*, https://www.govinfo.gov/content/pkg/CHRG-114shrg93025/html/CHRG-114shrg93025.htm.
[73] U.S. Department of Education, "Every Student Succeeds Act," https://www.ed.gov/laws-and-policy/laws-preschool-grade-12-education/every-student-succeeds-act-essa.

resources and educational experiences depending on place of residence, household income, race, disability, and the language used.[74] In the end, American education has served as an important means of expanding democracy and equality, but at the same time, it is also a system that reveals again the discrimination and inequality that exist in society within schools.

[74] U.S. Government Accountability Office, *K–12 Education: Student Population Has Significantly Diversified, but Many Schools Remain Divided Along Racial, Ethnic, and Economic Lines* (2022), https://www.gao.gov/products/gao-22-104737.

History (Korea)

Introduction

In 1953, immediately after the armistice of the Korean War, education became the method for rapid recovery. Policies framed education as a base for economic development[75], and the Korean government made efforts to eradicate illiteracy. Consequently, Korea experienced the Miracle of the Han River. Today, South Korea has one of the highest literacy rates in the world at 99 percent[76], and consistently scores high in standardized tests. Previous scholarship emphasizes the positive aspects of Korea's education system, particularly how a war-torn, poverty-stricken country could have become an education powerhouse,[77] and while economic historians highlight the role of education in South Korea's rapid growth, often crediting education with driving Korea's 'developmental state' model, scholars often overlook structural consequences of a system that achieves excellence through extreme competition. While the Korean education system excels in terms of raw grades, its hypercompetitive and test-centric means of evaluation is

[75]Ministry of Education. *Education, the Driving Force for the Development of Korea: Land of the Morning Calm Develops into a Prominent Player in the Global Economy*. Korean Education Centre UK, 2015, https://www.koreaneducentreinuk.org/wp-content/uploads/downloads/Education_the-driving-force-for-the-development-of-Korea.pdf

[76]World Bank. "Literacy Rate, Adult Total (% of People Ages 15 and Above) - Korea, Rep." *World Bank Open Data*, https://data.worldbank.org/indicator/SE.ADT.LITR.ZS?end=2018&locations=KR&start=2018&view=bar

[77]Clark W. Sorensen. "Success and Education in South Korea." *Comparative Education Review*, vol. 38, no. 1, 1994, pp. 10–35. https://doi.org/10.1086/447223

unsustainable. Korea has the highest teenage suicide rates among OECD countries,[78] and societal norms place a heavy emphasis on private tutoring known as "hagwon". For example, a household with four or more family members including at least two children spends more on private education than groceries and housing[79], and households widely report that having to pay for hagwons and private tutoring is a considerable financial burden for their family. Thus, the education system in its current form may cause mental health strain and reinforce social inequalities.

This paper argues that Korea's education system was not inevitable but historically contingent, emerging from war trauma, the influence of the Cold War and geopolitics, and authoritarian regimes that used education as a tool of state-building by developing human capital. Furthermore, this paper contends that the very policies credited with South Korea's educational success also entrenched the hypercompetitive structures that are responsible for mental health problems and persistent inequality. In order to understand how and why such a hypercompetitive education environment occurred, this paper will first provide a background on the legacies of Confucianism in Korean culture and Japanese colonial bureaucracy. Then, it will analyze the aftermath of the Korean War and its effects on South Korean education. Finally, it will assess the authoritarian regimes of Park Chung Hee and Chun Du Hwan.

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[78]Statistics Research Institute. "Korea Has the Highest Suicide Rate among OECD Countries." *Statistics Research Institute (통계개발원)*, Statistics Korea, https://sri.kostat.go.kr/board.es?mid=b10104000000&bid=12046&act=view&list_no=432657

[79]Kim, Min-jung. "South Korea's Education Fever Fuels Private Tutoring Boom." *The Chosun Daily*, 2 Oct. 2024, https://www.chosun.com/english/national-en/2024/10/02/AHPTCZL54NELFEHXJFZXWUI7YQ/

Background: Confucianist Influences in Education

Goryeo

Before 1984 with the Gabo Reformations, much of education was for the purpose of the civil service exam (Gwageo). First, in Korea, the primary education facility was Gukjagam, the highest institution of learning.[80] Education was centered around Confucianist principles, with the curriculum including works like Hyogyeong (Classic of Filial Piety) and Sangse (Book of Documents).[81] There were also provincial education institutions called Hyanggyo, modeled after the Tang dynasty system, as well as Hakdangs, government-run schools established to promote Confucian learning, and Sibi-dos/Seodangs, elementary-level schools which later directly influenced the Joseon dynasty's seodang system.[82] Thus, in Goryeo, education was mostly state-driven and focused on Confucianist principles, which focused on the moral legitimacy of hierarchy.[83]

Joseon and Gwageo

The situation was similar in Joseon with the Gwageo, a civil service exam, being the focal point of education. The civil service examination system of the Joseon Dynasty presented society not with an abstract ideal buried in the

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[80] *Goryeosa*, Vol. 74, Section on Selection & Schools (高麗史 卷七十四 選擧二學校)

[81]Moon, Cheol-young. "1930 Nyeondae Minjokjuui Sahak-ui Ilyangsang" ["An Aspect of Nationalist Historiography in the 1930s"]. *Guksagwan Nonchong* [국사관논총], vol. 9, National Institute of Korean History, 1989.

[82]Kim, Ho-il. *Hanguk-ui Hyanggyo* [한국의 향교]. Daewonsa, 2000.

[83]*Gyeongguk Daejeon* [경국대전]. Dongbang Media Co., KoreaA2Z Digital Contents Library, https://www.koreaa2z.com/viewer.php?seq=55

Confucian classics, but with a tangible and attainable model of success. Because the system maintained a degree of openness, it allowed individuals from various backgrounds to aspire to become admired figures and social role models. In this sense, the examination system served as a powerful driving force that sustained Joseon society as a Confucian educational state.[84] The examination system helped institutionalize educational aspiration throughout society, reinforcing the central role of learning and scholarly achievement in social advancement and going beyond just the selection of officials.[85]

The civil service examination system also had significant negative consequences for education. Rather than striving for knowledge itself, many scholars came to prioritize passing the state examinations as a means of achieving personal success and social advancement. As a result, everyday moral practice and the cultivation of human relationships were often neglected. In this process, the purpose of learning gradually shifted: scholarship was no longer pursued primarily for the benefit of society or for personal moral development, but increasingly became a tool for succeeding in the examinations; education became the means rather than the end.[86] The emphasis on examination success fostered a culture in which people were willing to use any means necessary to achieve their goals. By the late Joseon period, it became increasingly common for wealth and political influence to be used to buy and sell the prestige associated with examination success. Consequently, corruption, favoritism, and unfairness in the recruitment of

[84] Jeong, Se-hwa, and Eun-song Lee. *Gojeoneul Yeoneun Hanguk Gyoyuksa* [고전을 여는 한국교육사]. Yangseowon, 2011.

[85]Kim, Gyeong-yong. *Gwageo Jedowa Hanguk Geundaegyoyuk-ui Jaeinsik* [과거 제도와 한국 근대교육의 재인식]. Gyoyukgwahaksa, 2005.

[86]Jo, Jang-hun. *Daechidong: Hakbeoljuui-wa Budongsan Sinhwa-ga Mannaneun Got* [대치동: 학벌주의와 부동산 신화가 만나는 곳]. Sagyejeol, 2021.

government officials became widespread, undermining the integrity of the system and weakening its original meritocratic ideals. Also, although commoners were technically eligible to sit for the examinations[87], the financial costs and educational requirements involved in years of preparation made success difficult for most of them. As a result, the system functioned in practice as a mechanism for continuously reproducing the yangban elite and preserving the existing social hierarchy.

Japanese Colonial Bureaucratization of Schooling (1910–1945)

While colonial rule did not introduce Korean credentialism[88], it bureaucratized and rationed it, converting an already status-conscious examination culture into an instrument of ethnic stratification, and in doing so intensifying rather than dissolving the competitive pressures that would resurface, transformed, under the developmental state. It changed the mechanism for the credentialist culture from a more relatively open Confucian moral examination to a rationed and ethically-stratified bureaucratic gatekeeping system.[89] There were a total of four Joseon Education Ordinances in 1911, 1922, 1938, and 1943, and each marked a distinct phase, but to establish a background, the 1908 Decree concerning

[87]"Hyanggyo" [향교]. *Encyclopedia of Korean Culture* (한국민족문화대백과사전), The Academy of Korean Studies, https://encykorea.aks.ac.kr/Article/E0050078. Accessed 19 June 2026.

[88] "Korea's 'education fever' from the late nineteenth to the early twenty-first century," *Paedagogica Historica* (2022), tandfonline.com/doi/full/10.1080/0046760X.2022.2098391.

[89] Lee, J-K. (2002, March 7). Japanese higher education policy in Korea during the colonial period (1910-1945). Education Policy Analysis Archives, 10(14). Retrieved from http://epaa.asu.edu/epaa/v10n14.html/.

private schools gave the colonial government regulatory authority over the fundamentals of a school including its founding purpose, headteachers, teachers, and textbooks at every private school. Critically, it banned teaching geography and history, linked to nationalism, and the Bible, targeting missionary-run school networks. This led to the collapse of such schools, from 1,973 in 1910 to 690 in 1919, a 65% decline over nine years. This shows suppression as a process of attrition through licensing, not a single decree shutting schools down: bureaucratic strangulation rather than overt closure had a bigger impact on Korean education than could be seen.[90]

The 1911 Ordinance

The 1911 Ordinance came with the purpose of cultivating "loyal imperial subjects" and low-level workers. This ordinance used ideological conditioning, and education, instead of for the purpose of fostering critical thinking or national consciousness, mainly taught obedience to the Japanese emperor and state. Job training education was also similar—education was focused on practical training suited to filling subordinate roles in the colonial economy such as clerks, laborers, and low-skill technicians. The Japanese language was also used as a core assimilation tool, and the Japanese government attempted to end the Korean linguistic and cultural identity over time, attempting to make "Japaneseness" the norm Koreans had to assimilate into and laying the groundwork for deeper assimilation policies.[91]

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[90] Glavin, Chris. "Japanese Rule (1910–1945)." *K12 Academics*, 7 Feb. 2017, www.k12academics.com/Education%20Worldwide/Education%20in%20South%20Korea/History/History%20of%20Education%20in%20Korea/japanese-rule-191.

[91] Suh, Jiwon. "Japan's Education Policies in Korea in the 1910s: 'Thankful and Obedient.'" *Journal of Korean Studies*, vol. 25, no. 1, 2020, pp. 115–45. *Duke University Press*, doi.org/10.1215/21581665-8047512.

This ordinance also aimed to demote missionary colleges who were notably outside of direct Japanese state control and worked to revoke their authority to grant degrees and to downgrade them to a lesser status, closer to an unaccredited school, to eliminate an independent, non-Japanese-controlled channel for Korean higher education and reinforced that all legitimate education had to run through the colonial state.[92]

The 1922 Ordinance

Following the 1919 March 1st Movement was the 1922 Ordinance, which acted more as a "cultural rule" concession with separate Japanese/Korean tracks. The 1919 March 1st Movement was a nationwide uprising that shocked Japan into realizing that the harsh, "military rule" (budan seiji) approach was unsustainable and was fueling resistance instead.[93] In response, Japan shifted to a "cultural rule" (bunka seiji), a softer and more image-conscious style of colonial governance. The 1922 ordinance was part of this. While this ordinance formally separated school tracks for Japanese settlers and Koreans, it also loosened the rule so that Koreans could now attend "normal schools" like teacher-training schools.[94] Moreover, as a response to Korean intellectuals' request to establish a Korean-run national university, the colonial government preempted it by founding Keijō Imperial

[92] United States Army Military Government in Korea. *History of the United States Army Military Government in Korea*. Korean History Database, db.history.go.kr/contemp/level.do?levelId=husa_004_0020_0030&types=o. Accessed 21 June 2026.

[93] "The Lingering Shadows of Japanese Words in Korean Identity." *The Argus*, 5 Dec. 2025, www.theargus.org/news/articleView.html?idxno=3160.

[94] Government-General of Chōsen, Educational Bureau. *Revised Educational Regulations for Chosen*. Keijō, 9 Feb. 1922. Quoted in United States Army Military Government in Korea, *History of the United States Army Military Government in Korea*, Korean History Database, db.history.go.kr/contemp/level.do?levelId=husa_004_0020_0030&types=o. Accessed 21 June 2026.

University in Seoul as a state-run, Japanese-administered institution.[95] This absorbed the momentum and demand for a Korean university[96] but kept it firmly under state control, rather than letting Koreans build and run their own. [97]

The 1938 Ordinance

The third phase of colonial education policy was the 1938 Education Ordinance. In 1939, Japan was deep into its preparations for the Second Sino-Japanese War (1937), and colonial policy pivoted from one to "manage and pacify" into one for a full wartime mobilization", and accordingly, this era was called "Japan and Korea as one body" (naisen ittai), the most aggressive assimilation push of the entire colonial period. To achieve this, first, Korean was downgraded to an optional elective.[98] In practice, removing mandatory learning where Japanese was already the dominant language of instruction and advancement in terms of state favor meant it was functionally eliminated, as choosing it actively disadvantaged students. Second was the National Mobilization Law that conscripted students for labor. School time was redirected into labor service including agricultural and factory work to support the military's endeavors overseas, and education

[95] Cha, Eun-Jeong. "The Imaginary Reconstruction of Keijō Imperial University." *Korean Anthropology Review*, vol. 7, Feb. 2023, pp. 145–70. *Seoul National University Open Repository*, s-space.snu.ac.kr/bitstream/10371/189926/1/Cha%20Eun-Jeong_2023_KAR.pdf.

[96] Lee, Chong-Jae, et al. "Higher Education in Korea: An Historical and Institutional Analysis." *Education Policy Analysis Archives*, vol. 10, no. 14, 7 Mar. 2002, epaa.asu.edu/index.php/epaa/article/download/293/419.

[97] Park, Yunjae. "Training Medical Researchers in Korea during the Japanese Colonial Period (1910–1945)." *History of Universities, Volume XXXIV/1: A Global History of Research Education*, edited by Vassiliki Theodorou et al., Oxford UP, 2021, academic.oup.com/book/39837/chapter/339982647.

[98] Caprio, Mark E. *Japanese Assimilation Policies in Colonial Korea, 1910–1945*. University of Washington Press, 2009.

no longer had the luxury to even be nominally about training subjects or controlling access and became a pipeline directly into the war economy.[99]

The 1943 Ordinance

The fourth and final phase of colonial education policy was the 1943 Educational Ordinance. At this point, Japan was in the late stage of the Pacific War, and education policy collapsed into wartime extraction. Not only was the Korean language eliminated entirely from middle schools, completing the naisen ittai assimilation logic, but 250,000+ Koreans were conscripted by 1945, escalating from just redirecting school time into labor. Consequently, according to the 1944 Japanese census, 86.2% of the population were never schooled, with only 1% reaching secondary school and above. In terms of gender, 95% of Korean women never attended school at all, against an already-low baseline for men.[100]

An Examination of Empirical Data

Statistics from this period of time reflect this. First, according to the data compiled by Grajdanzev, approximately 0.0093 per 1,000 Koreans went to college, while 1.06 per 1,000 Japanese residents in Korea did, a 11400% difference. What makes this so stark is that the number is a population-wide rate produced by a system that funneled resources and opportunities to the comparatively small population transplanted for colonization. In the

[99] Robinson, Michael E. *Korea's Twentieth-Century Odyssey: A Short History*. University of Hawai'i Press, 2007.

[100] Oh, Seung-Cheol, and Ki-Seok Kim. "The Increase of Educational Opportunity in Korea under the Japanese Occupation: For Whom the Bell Told?" *The SNU Journal of Education Research*, 1997, s-space.snu.ac.kr/bitstream/10371/72664/1/05.pdf.

pre-colonial world, Joseon-era status was tightly bound to passing the civil service exam, a meritocratic ladder tied to Confucian learning. In one study, areas that had more gwageo passers under the Joseon dynasty were later found to be the same areas with more Korean teachers and private schools functioning as alternatives to the colonial public school system. This means that the pre-colonial infrastructure of local prestige and communities organized around scholarly credentialing didn't disappear when the dynasty fell.[101] Through colonization, the ladder changed to a state-licensed, ethnically-rationed system with fixed school slots and government control over curriculum and accreditation, leading to such a structural ceiling shown by the difference in second education pursuit. Consequently, this made credentials scarcer and more contested than before. Therefore, the rationing of the cultural reflex that education is status sharpened the competitive intensity around it: Keijō University's pyramid structure became the template for Seoul National University's position at the top of the modern university hierarchy of Korea, and the competitive intensity that colonial rationing produced is the same intensity that resurfaces, supercharged, under Park Chung Hee's developmental state.[102]

War, Rupture, and Emergency Expansion (1945–1959)

Liberation in 1945 officially unraveled the colonial apparatus of ethnic gatekeeping, including the separation of Japanese settlers from Koreans, the fixed quotas, and the licensing regime throttling missionary and Korean-run

[101] Hong, Ji Yeon, and Christopher Paik. "Colonization and Education: Exploring the Legacy of Local Elites in Korea." *Economic History Review*, vol. 71, no. 3, 2018, pp. 938–964.

[102] Neuhaus, Carolin. "Beyond Assimilation and National Resistance: 'Education Fever' during the Colonial Period in Korea, 1910–1945." *History of Education*, vol. 52, no. 4, 2023, pp. 533–554.

schools, but the underlying idea that schooling was scarce and related to status, and therefore worth disproportionate sacrifice to obtain, did not change. Liberation only removed the justification for that scarcity, not the scarcity itself, and the Korean War only made the shortage worse, destroying schools and displacing teachers and students at the exact moment the new state needed mass education to prove its legitimacy as a sovereign nation. Competition over education found a new alibi in the urgency of national reconstruction. It is also worth noting that in 1945, fewer than 20 percent of Koreans had ever attended any school, and the national literacy rate was around 22 percent.

Liberation and the Collapse of the Colonial Apparatus

When Japan surrendered in August, 1945, Korea south of the 38th parallel came under the USAMGIK administration until the foundation of Republic of Korea in August 1948. By its own admission and by most historians' assessments, USAMGIK was improvising: it had little Korean expertise, with almost no Korean-speaking staff and arrived with the occupation doctrine built more for postwar Japan than for a decolonizing country.[103] Consequently, USAMGIK did not have the time or an alternate cadre of administrators ready for a dismantling of the Japanese colonial education systems. The buildings, registries, and institutional hierarchy used were therefore the ones that existed. The same bureaucratic personnel of Korean teachers and administrators trained and credentialed under the colonial system remained, and the curriculum, including the exam-gated

[103] "An Unpromising Recovery: South Korea's Post-Korean War Economic Development: 1953-1961." *Education About Asia*, Association for Asian Studies, 16 June 2023, www.asianstudies.org/publications/eaa/archives/an-unpromising-recovery-south-koreas-post-korean-war-economic-development-1953-1961/.

transitions between school levels and the colonial-era management tools for rationing education to a colonized population remained.[104] USAMGIK and Korean educators, however, worked to change the symbolic and linguistic content quickly: Japanese-language instruction was abolished essentially overnight, and Korean (Hangul) was reinstated as the medium of instruction, with Colonial-era textbooks being hastily revised and Korean-authored materials produced under a significant time pressure.[105] Liberation also triggered a surge in demand for Korean-language schooling that the existing infrastructure couldn't absorb: adult literacy programs, accelerated primary enrollment, and a national sentiment of education as a national right increased, while the supply of trained teachers, textbooks, and space was constrained. An improvisation of single-teacher, single-classroom arrangement resulted, often combining multiple grades and with cramped classrooms. Therefore, while the ethnic axis of exclusion was gone after 1945, the underlying scarcity remained, and the rationing mechanisms like centralized control and exams remained. This meant that the system needed another variable to sort by, and class background, urban/rural location, and the ability to pay, or the access to information largely determined a student's access to education.

[104] United States Army Military Government in Korea. "Ordinance No. 6." *Selected Ordinances of the Military Government*.

[105] Yoon, Jong Mun. "The Policy and Characteristics of Sending Korean Students to the United States during the Early U.S. Military Government Period." *Studies in Modern Korean History*, no. 63, 2012, pp. 178-210. Korean Citation Index (KCI)

The 1949 Education Act and the Promise of Mass Schooling

In 1949, The Education Act came into force under the newly founded First Republic. It formalized the single-track 6-3-3-4 ladder system invented by the Council for Korean Education under USAMGIK rather than by the Rhee Government. On compulsory education specifically, the underlying constitutional commitment predates the Act itself; the 1948 Constitution already stated that elementary education is compulsory and free of charge, and that all citizens have the right to receive education equally according to ability.[106] The 1949 Act then operationalized this, and compulsory education formally began on June 1, 1950, just weeks before the Korean War broke out. The Act also carried explicit ideological content, adopting the motto Hong'ik in'gan ("to benefit humanity"), attributed to Korea's founder according to legend, Tan'gun.[107] This shows that the state anchored the purpose of education in a continuous national identity stretching before, through, and after the colonial interruption.

At this stage, Korea was among the poorest in the world at the time, with GDP per capita estimated at only $50 to $60. Between 70 and 80 percent of the population worked in agriculture, and infrastructure was severely constrained, with electricity self-sufficiency at only 8 percent, since most power plants built during the colonial era were concentrated in the North, a now separate and hostile state.[108] This resulted in retrenchment almost

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[106] "Primary Education." *Ministry of Education*, Republic of Korea, english.moe.go.kr/sub/infoRenewal.do?m=0303&page=0303&s=english.

[107] Savada, Andrea Matles, and William Shaw, editors. *South Korea: A Country Study*. Federal Research Division, Library of Congress, 1990.

[108] "When Mandatory Education Began in South Korea." *Korea JoongAng Daily*, www.koreajoongangdaily.com/opinion/when-mandatory-education-began-in-south-korea/12528656.

immediately. USAMGIK-era ambitions had floated compulsory education up to the ninth grade and co-education at all levels, but the Rhee government reversed many of these reforms after 1948; only primary schools remained generally coeducational, and because of a lack of resources, compulsory education was scaled back to the sixth grade only. Despite that, the mandate did drive real changes: the compulsory-education requirement led to widespread school construction, and by the end of the First Republic, primary-school enrollment had topped 95 percent, albeit under severe resource constraints.[109] While universal education eliminated disparities between classes at that level, competition became very fierce due to restricted entry into higher academic tiers, which contributed to the "education fever" still prevalent in South Korea today.

The Korean War as Infrastructural Rupture

The heavy damage of the war furthered Korea's struggles for a stable education environment. Studies report around 40 percent to more than half of school buildings in South Korea were destroyed during the war, with school closures nationwide.[110] Teachers and students were displaced into improvised settings almost immediately; by 1953, classes were being held everywhere space could be found, including abandoned factories and tents, and because of a severe teacher shortage, class sizes ballooned to as many as

[109] "Investing in Foundational Skills First: A Case from South Korea." *RISE Programme*, riseprogramme.org/sites/default/files/2023-01/Investing_Foundational_Skills_First_South%20Korea.pdf.

[110] Lee et al. "The Rise of Korean Education from the Ashes of the Korean War." *ResearchGate*, 6 Sept. 2012, www.researchgate.net/publication/257641219_The_rise_of_Korean_education_from_the_ashes_of_the_Korean_War.

100 students, running in two or even three shifts in a day. In some places, teachers were even forced to meet their classes outdoors without textbooks or writing paper.[111] Despite this, Korea's education didn't falter: by spring 1951, while the war was still ongoing, around 60 percent of schools had reopened, and two-thirds of the country's children were back in class while communities worked together to raise funds and rebuild.[112] Despite the destruction of buildings due to the war, between 1945 and 1960, primary enrollment grew threefold, secondary schooling eightfold, and higher education tenfold. Moreover, the demand pressure became so acute that it forced a major policy response right at the close of the war: in 1953, comprehensive entrance exams were instituted for middle and high school, an effort to balance demand for higher education against limited secondary provision and the state's desire to regulate the supply of advanced-degree holders.[113] The primary school enrollment rate jumped from 54 to 96 percent from 1945 to 1959 through a government-run "Six-Year Plan to Complete Mandatory Education", and this meant that this expansion was bottom-heavy, as it was deliberately done in a sequential and low-cost strategy.[114] Only during '60s and '70s was access to secondary education possible, when the state had to implement an explicit "equalization policy"

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[111] Kyung Sik Ahn. "A Study of Refugee Schools in Wartime Capital Busan During the Korean War: Focusing on Secondary Schools". *Korea Citation Index*, www.kci.go.kr/kciportal/landing/article.kci?arti_id=ART001404558.

[112] Woody Paik. "Opinion: What the U.S. Can Learn About Education During Crisis from South Korea's Wartime Example." *The Hechinger Report*, 11 June 2020, hechingerreport.org/opinion-what-the-u-s-can-learn-about-education-during-crisis-from-south-koreas-wartime-example/.

[113] Klaus Dittrich, et al. "Korea's 'Education Fever' from the Late Nineteenth to the Twenty-First Century." *Comparative Education*, Taylor & Francis, 2022, www.tandfonline.com/doi/full/10.1080/0046760X.2022.2098391.

[114] "Investments in Education." *K-Developedia*, KDI School of Public Policy and Management, www.kdevelopedia.org/Development-Overview/all/investments-education--201412120000423.do.

to reduce competition for entrance to prestigious middle and high schools. There were also socioeconomic barriers to entry in middle school: middle school was not compulsory at this time and it was costly for a family member to not work. At this period of time, despite the massive increase in the enrollment rate of primary schools, less than 2 percent of the population had ever been enrolled in higher education.[115]

Developmental Dictatorship and Human Capital Engineering (1960s–1980s)

By 1959, the structure inherited by colonial and wartime Korea had shaped into a pyramid with near-universal primary enrollment sitting atop a steep, narrowing pyramid, with a competitive entrance examination already institutionalized in 1953 as the gatekeeping mechanism for secondary and tertiary access. The developmental state that Park Chung Hee established following his 1961 coup directly inherited this architecture. What Park's regime did was subordinate it entirely to the logic of national economic planning as instruments of labor allocation instead of keeping schools the sites of citizen-building in the alibi of the Rhee era. In doing so, it supercharged the competitive pressure accumulated since the colonial period; each intervention designed to rationalize or equalize the system instead displaced competition upward, until the college entrance examination became the singular, totalizing pressure point it remains today. The collapse of authoritarian guarantees after democratization in 1987, and

[115] "History of Korea as a Foreign Aid Recipient." *Google Arts & Culture*, Korea International Cooperation Agency, artsandculture.google.com/story/history-of-korea-as-a-foreign-aid-recipient-korea-international-cooperation-agency/KAWBKWNerP_GKA.

the economic trauma of the 1997 IMF crisis, then completed the transformation. What the state had administered as a public system of human capital production was progressively reframed as a private investment families were responsible for making on their own at whatever cost the market demanded.

Education Under Authoritarian Modernization

Quite notably, Park Chung Hee arrived at education through economics: immediately after seizing power in the 1961 coup, his regime redirected an already-functioning apparatus towards new ends. In 1961, South Korea already had near-universal primary enrollment, with 96% by 1959, but secondary and tertiary education access remained bottlenecked. Moreover, a centralized Ministry of Education was already established and had institutionalized a competitive entrance exam as the gatekeeping mechanism for secondary and tertiary education, a pyramid that the Rhee era built but could not fund adequately.[116] With this system, Park simply shifted the alibi from the citizen-building focus of Rhee's nationalist regime rooted in the 1949 Education Act's Hong'ik in'gan framing to human capital production rooted in the Five-Year Plans, Park's developmental idiom. He attempted this through an identical mechanism with centralized gatekeeping and an exam-mediated rationing of scarce upper-tier seats, but the stated purpose changed.[117]

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[116] Lee, Eun-Jeung. "The 1960s in South Korea: Modernisation, Nationalism and the Pursuit of Democratisation." *International Quarterly for Asian Studies*, vol. 52, nos. 3-4, 2021, pp. 187-205. https://doi.org/10.11588/iqas.2021.3-4.16181

[117]Isozaki, Noriyo. "Education, Development, and Politics in South Korea." *Emerging States at Crossroads: Development, Environment, and Political Economy*, edited by Keiichi Tsunekawa and Yasuyuki Todo, Springer, Singapore, 2019, pp. 209-229. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-981-13-2859-6_10

Park's educational policies were heavily influenced by his economic policies, most notably with the Five-Year Plans acting as a master logic, framing education as a factor of production. The first Five-Year Plans in 1962 to 1966, announced immediately after the coup, laid the foundation with park constructing a system where state funds were allocated to the private sector via financial institutions, placing the state in control of the resources necessary to sustain its developmental agenda. It primarily focused on light manufacturing, agricultural modernization, and basic infrastructure, which requires low-to-mid skill workers, not university graduates.[118] The second Five-Year Plan during 1967 to 1971 predicted a labor shortage with the Economic Planning Board (EPB), which caused the expansion of vocational training programs, where labor-supply planning and education policy were often merged together. This period of time is also when Park raised the target annual growth rate in Korea.[119] The third Five-Year Plan established a compulsory employer training system where large employers were required to provide workplace training or pay a levy funding governmental programs; this stage formally mandated vocational and technical education, a qualitative shift in state control over the labor pipeline. Lastly, with the Heavy and Chemical Industry Policy (HCI Drive) targeting steel, nonferrous metals, shipbuilding, machinery, electronics, and chemicals, manpower policy now required experts in engineering, which drove the reorientation of vocational school curriculum from craft skills toward engineering. Here, the HCI Planning Committee (HCIPC) and its Secretariat controlled vocational education and training policy during this period, not the Ministry of Education: Oh Won-Chul, Park's second Senior

[118] Amsden, Alice H. *Asia's Next Giant: South Korea and Late Industrialization*. Oxford UP, 1989.

[119] Fleckenstein, Timo, Soohyun Christine Lee, and Jaehyoung Park. "Skills and Training in Hierarchical Capitalism: The Rise and Fall of Vocational Training in South Korea." *Journal of Contemporary Asia*, vol. 54, no. 2, 2024, pp. 260-281. Taylor & Francis, https://doi.org/10.1080/00472336.2023.2168207

Economic Secretary held manpower policy within the Blue House, showing that education was used as a factor of production during this time.[120]

The primary institutional vehicle through which Park translated economic planning into educational structure was the vocational high school system, a deliberately tiered track designed not to broaden opportunity but to sort it, channeling students toward the specific skill profiles each successive Five-Year Plan required. Specifically, Park explicitly did not want rapid university expansion: economically, the light industry in the 1960s required craft skills and degrees only produced overeducated workers for available jobs, and politically, university students were the protest base that brought down Rhee in 1960 via the April Revolution, and expanding their numbers were a political risk.[121] With Park's personal background as a former officer in the Japanese-controlled Manchukuo Imperial Army and later the Japanese Imperial Army, the Japanese colonial developmental model including its vocational education apparatus, was directly familiar to him.[122] This system was further solidified using Germany as an explicit institutional template after Park visited West Germany in 1964. The German dual system, or the Meister model, became the explicit reference point for Korean vocational education design, also furthering ties between Korea and

[120] Stern, Joseph J., Jihong Kim, Dwight H. Perkins, and Jungho Yoo. *Industrialization and the State: The Korean Heavy and Chemical Industry Drive*. Harvard Institute for International Development and Korea Development Institute, 1995.

[121] Seth, Michael J. *Education Fever: Society, Politics, and the Pursuit of Schooling in South Korea*. University of Hawai'i Press, 2002.

[122] Eckert, Carter J. *Park Chung Hee and Modern Korea: The Roots of Militarism, 1866–1945*. Harvard University Press, 2016.

Germany along with a labor export deal with Korean miners and nurses.[123] The first phase established vocational high schools to supply mid-level technicians for textiles, plywood, and footwear, the labor-intensive light export industries of the first two Five-Year Plans. Entry required a principal's letter of recommendation, and government scholarships attracted strong students regardless of family income background.[124] The second phase reoriented the curriculum toward engineering as the HCI Drive restructured the economy: the number of vocational trainees near-tripled in three years driven by rising public training programs and mandatory workplace training, and technical high schools and polytechnics trained over 100,000 workers annually by the 1980s in fields like machinery and electronics. Here, the vocational track was designed to be a productive alternative to the university path, but it still served as a prestige track inserted into a credential hierarchy whose apex was still the university degree.

The same administrative logic that had allowed the Government-General of Chōsen to control Korean education from a single center was perfected under Park. During both the Rhee and Park years, authority over education moved progressively out of local school boards into the Ministry of Education: by the 1980s, the Ministry controlled all basic policy decisions including administration of schools, allocation of resources, setting of enrollment quotas, certification of schools and teachers, and curriculum development including textbook guidelines.[125] Provincial and city school

[123] Park, Jaeho, and Sang-Hoon Yu. "Labor Market Performance Gaps: The Role of Vocational Education in South Korea." *Cogent Education*, vol. 10, no. 2, 2023, Article 2250108. Taylor & Francis, https://doi.org/10.1080/2331186X.2023.2250108

[124] Seth, Michael J. *Education Fever: Society, Politics, and the Pursuit of Schooling in South Korea*. University of Hawai'i Press, 2002.

[125] Savada, Andrea Matles, and William Shaw, editors. *South Korea: A Country Study*. Federal Research Division, Library of Congress, 1992. U.S. Government Printing Office.

boards nominally continued to exist but ceased to function as independent bodies after 1973. In October 1972, Park dissolved the National Assembly, suspended the constitution, declared martial law, and closed all universities and colleges. The Yushin Constitution, promulgated in December 1972 with an implausible 92.3% gave Park unlimited presidential terms and other sweeping emergency powers, highly centralizing the government.[126] Even etymologically, *Yushin* is the Korean pronunciation of the Japanese *Ishin* (restoration), directly referencing the 1868 Meiji Restoration, whose educational and industrial apparatus Park had grown up inside as a colonial subject and imperial officer: the colonial model is consciously invoked here.[127] This centralization reflects a broader pattern across Korea's history of education: the Government-General of Joseon's administrative logic with a single central authority controlling access, curriculum, credential, and the supply of educated Koreans continues in the Park-era Ministry of Education's administrative logic, with a single central authority controlling everything: the mechanism is identical even if the alibi has changed from ethnic stratification to economic development.[128]

In 1968, the Third Republic adopted the Charter of National Education, outlining four goals for education: national revitalization, creating self-reliant individuals, promulgating a cooperative national image, and

[126] Jeong, Minji, and Youseop Shin. "Post-War Korean Conservatism, Japanese Statism, and the Legacy of President Park Chung-hee in South Korea." *The Korean Journal of International Studies*, vol. 16, no. 1, 2018, pp. 57-76. https://doi.org/10.14731/kjis.2018.04.16.1.57.

[127] Eckert, Carter J. *Park Chung Hee and Modern Korea: The Roots of Militarism, 1866–1945*. Harvard University Press, 2016.

[128] Neuhaus, Dörte. "Beyond Assimilation and National Resistance: Colonial Education and the Formation of Korean Subjects under Japanese Rule." *History of Education*, vol. 52, no. 5, 2023, pp. 843-861. Taylor & Francis, https://doi.org/10.1080/0046760X.2022.2161624

supporting anti-communism. Students were required to recite this in elementary schools, functioning more like a daily ideological ritual. This shows that the education system of this era ran two logics simultaneously: the economic logic with the sorting of labor and focus on human capital production for the Five-Year Plans, and the ideological logic, with anti-communist nationalism and loyalty to the developmental state. Moreover, rather they reinforce each other, as a disciplined, nationalist, and anti-communist workforce was exactly what the developmental dictatorship needed: the state needed both obedient ideology-bearers and competitive exam-passers, and the system was designed to produce both. The Third Republic's solution to the student protest problem also revealed the relationship between academic competition and political control: the government allowed universities and colleges to recruit up to 130% of their graduation quotas, so that student activists would be forced to compete against one another in order to graduate. This shows that the competitive exam system was also deployed as a political mechanism to keep university students too busy and individually competitive to organize collectively.

By the late 1970s, the developmental state had achieved what it set out to achieve: secondary enrollment at 90 percent, the vocational track operational, and the HCI Drive producing the engineering cohorts heavy industry required. Measured against its own objectives, the system worked. What it had not done, however, was alter the competitive logic the paper has traced from the colonial period forward. The equalization policy, which abolished middle and high school entrance examinations in stages between 1969 and 1975, had tried and failed. Removing the lower gates did not reduce competitive pressure; it concentrated it entirely onto the single remaining gate, the college entrance examination, which now bore the full weight of a society's credential anxiety alone. That concentration is the

inheritance every subsequent government receives, and the inability to undo it is the subject of what follows.

Policy Intention and Outcome

By the late 1960s, "examination hell" at the secondary level was severe enough to produce political pressures for reform: students cramming for middle school entrance exams from elementary school with a significant number repeating grades to improve performance, and the curriculum at all lower levels distorted towards exam preparation. Specifically, high-profile exam-error scandals in Seoul triggered a middle school reform. Thus, the Middle School Equalization Policy was born. This completely abolished middle school entrance examinations and implemented lottery-based enrollment when applicants exceed a school's capacity, equalizing education levels across schools and removing the need for prestigious middle schools, as this policy was applied universally to private schools as well.[129]

This was also implemented in high school some years later. In 1974, the High School Equalization Policy was introduced to explicitly address overheated competition for prestigious high schools and the resulting concentration of students in urban areas. High school applicants were now screened with a regional uniform examination then allocated to individual schools within their district by lottery, ignoring school rankings. Private schools were also now required to charge the same tuition and teach the same curriculum as public schools: the government subsidized private school teachers' salaries to match public school rates.

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[129] Kim, Sunwoong, and Ju-Ho Lee. *Secondary School Equalization Policies in South Korea*. KDI School of Public Policy and Management, 2002.

With these two policies, by 1998, nearly 100% of elementary school graduates proceeded to middle school, and middle school enrollment rose 2,347% from 1945 to 1999.[130] However, these equalization policies did not end examination pressure; it merely relocated it upward, concentrating the entirety of credential competition onto the university entrance examination.[131] This is because removing the lower gates while leaving the upper gate of university admission intact and unchanged means the system now has one point of failure instead of three, and thus, the stakes of a single exam rise accordingly. Furthermore, abolishing ranked schools did not abolish the social memory of school rankings, and the prestige of preexisting elite middle schools persisted afterwards for decades. The virtual nationalization of private schools also removed school diversity and competition among schools, creating little incentive for schools to respond to the needs of students and parents while doing nothing to remove the motive for competition among students.[132] Lastly, by the 1980s, the vocational high school, designed in the 1960s as a productive alternative track with genuine initial prestige, is now regarded as the destination for students who failed to qualify for academic high schools. This shows that the intervention does not change the underlying incentive of status credential, so is defeated by it: both the equalization policy and the vocational track represent attempts to work around the credential hierarchy,

[130] "Secondary Education and Middle Schools and High Schools in South Korea." *Facts and Details*, edited by Mark Cartwright, Facts and Details, https://factsanddetails.com/korea/South_Korea/Education_Health_Transportation_Infrastructure/entry-7378.html

[131] Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development. *Education Reform in Korea*. OECD Publishing, 2013, https://doi.org/10.1787/9789264190673-en.

[132] Sorensen, Clark W. "Popular Demand and Education in South Korea." *Comparative Education Review*, vol. 36, no. 3, 1992, pp. 307–324. University of Chicago Press, https://doi.org/10.1086/447127

and neither touches the hierarchy itself, so both are ultimately absorbed by it.

The Park era was a system that has successfully produced the workforce the developmental state required while generating, as its structural byproduct, an exam pressure more concentrated and more socially totalizing than anything that came before. The state's response to this byproduct, first under Park, then under Chun Doo Hwan, is prohibition: a ban on hagwons or private tutoring and the market response to a market failure the state itself created.

Collapse of State Educational Guarantees

The July 30, 1980 education reform was the act of a government with no political legitimacy attempting to manufacture social legitimacy through egalitarian policy. Its failure reveals, more directly than any prior intervention, the structural impossibility of suppressing educational competition without first dismantling the credential hierarchy that makes competition rational. 1980 was especially important because it directly followed the rise of power of Chun through the coup d'état of December, 1979, following Park's assassination, then the consolidation through the May 17 coup and the brutal suppression of the Gwangju Uprising in May of 1980 in which soldiers fired on civilian protests.[133] The July 30 Education Reform landed merely six weeks after Gwangju, which means it was more than a coincidence and rather a gesture meant to build legitimacy from a government that could not afford dissent. The ban's egalitarian rationale

[133] "Gwangju Uprising (1980)." *Historical Parallax*, Historical Parallax, 22 Dec. 2025, https://historical.parallax.kr/a/gwangju-uprising-1980

and mentions of "unfair burdens on the poor" was a political one that positioned the regime as a defender of ordinary families against elite privilege at the precise moment it is suppressing those families' political rights by force. Seen from a broader context of social policy, the Chun government simultaneously introduced the so-called "3S Policy" loosening the censorship restrictions and expanding televised sports, including hosting the 1988 Olympics, to redirect public attention toward entertainment; the education ban also fits the same logic of managing dissent through social policy rather than democratic accountability.[134]

The July 30, 1980 Reform's official title was "A Plan to Take Public Education Back to the Normal Stage and Resolve the Overheated Problem of Private Education": the title itself frames private education as a deviation from a norm the public system represents, which is the reform's core ideological claim.[135] The stated rationale here, interestingly, is explicitly egalitarian: Chun contends that because not many parents can afford education, allowing hagwons, or private academies, to thrive hands an unfair advantage to rich families who can afford supplementary studies.[136] Thus, enforcement was severe, targeted, and class-conscious: the ban specifically emphasized the prohibition of tutoring for children of socially influential people including public officials, businessmen, doctors, or lawyers; violators faced public disclosure of their names, expulsion from public office, tax investigation, or even police raids in places where illegal tutoring operations

[134] Kim, Hak-Sun. "The New Military Regime's 'Accelerated Rule' and 3Ss Policy." *Society and History*, no. 136, 2022, pp. 255-306. https://doi.org/10.37743/SAH.136.9

[135] Bae, Sang Hoon, and Kee Ho Choi. "The Cause of Institutionalized Private Tutoring in Korea: Defective Public Schooling or a Universal Desire for Family Reproduction?" *ECNU Review of Education*, vol. 7, no. 1, 2024, pp. 12-41. SAGE Publications, https://doi.org/10.1177/20965311231182722.
[136] "All You Need to Know About TOEFL and SAT Hagwons in Korea." *Expat Schools Seoul Korea*, https://expatschoolskorea.com/article/all-you-need-to-know-about-toefl-and-sat-hagwons-in-korea.html

were suspected.[137] Initially, the ban's egalitarian framing resonated with a lot of people and received genuine public support, which makes its failure more analytically significant.

The 1980 ban is the purest illustration of the paper's central structural argument: every intervention that suppresses the expression of competitive pressure without altering the incentive structure that generates it will fail, and will typically produce outcomes that are worse than those it tried to prevent. In the case of this ban, it merely drove the competition underground: the ban suppressed supply without changing demand, as the university entrance exam and therefore the credential hierarchy was unchanged. Tutors now ended up simply charging premium rates for discretion, which meant only wealthier families could afford them. The enforcement apparatus itself becomes evidence of the ban's failure. In one instance, a foreign English teacher described being one of many "cowboy" and "backpack" tutors evading the "language police" investigators throughout the 1990s, a decade after the ban. Even in this time, the illegal tutoring economy was still so large it required ongoing policing.[138] This shows a deep irony: the ban ended up producing the exact inequality it was designed to prevent; the gap in educational investment by income only widened under the prohibition as wealthy families absorbed the risk premium of illegal tutoring while poor families lost even the cheaper group-hagwon option that had previously been accessible. Even the president of Seoul National University resigned in 1998 after it was revealed that his wife arranged private tutoring for their daughter; the most powerful

[137] "Hagwon: South Korea's $23 Billion Private Tutoring Industry and the Education Arms Race." *Seoul Vision 2030*, 2025, https://seoulvision2030.com/glossary/hagwon/

[138] Lartigue, Casey J., Jr. "You'll Never Guess What South Korea Frowns Upon." *Cato Institute*, 28 May 2000, https://www.cato.org/commentary/youll-never-guess-what-south-korea-frowns-upon

symbol of public education in the country was caught violating a law designed to protect it.

The administration was therefore forced to proceed incremental relaxation of progressive: university tutors were granted the permission to teach privately first following the June Democratic Uprising of 1987 that forced Chun to accept democratic elections meant the political basis for authoritarian enforcement of the ban began to erode immediately. Then, limited educational establishments received licenses, then the ban unraveled under market and political pressure without ever being formally repealed. In 1991, middle and high school students were formally permitted to take extracurricular courses at authorized private educational institutions for the first time since 1980. Finally, the constitutional court ruled the total ban on private tutoring unconstitutional in 2000, citing violations of individual rights to education and occupational freedom and free market principles. This marked the transition from the state trying to suppress the private education market to the state trying to regulate it. Even after the ruling, official discomfort existed: President Kim Dae Jung continued to oppose private tutoring on the same egalitarian grounds as Chun, ordering the Ministry of Education to coordinate with the National Tax Office to trace finances of anyone overcharging for private tutoring. The continuity of official rhetoric across Chun, a military dictator, and Kim Dae Jung, known for his opposition to Chun is striking, especially since both failed to suppress it. The small-sized tutoring institutions running covertly through the 1980s and 1990s that could not be quelled became the direct institutional predecessors of the neighborhood hagwons that multiplied after the Constitutional Court finding, showing that the prohibition could only reorganize but not erase it.

The intersection of the Constitutional Court's 2000 ruling and the economic trauma of the 1997 IMF crisis produces the hagwon economy as it exists today. From 1990 to 2000, the number of hagwons nearly doubled in ten years, from 28,862 to 57,935, driven by deregulation meeting demand that had been suppressed underground. Moreover, between 2000 and 2025, the number of registered hagwons grew further to approximately 85,000, and household spending on private education roughly tripled in real terms. By the early 2000s, 90 percent of all students interviewed at a primary school in Seoul reported taking private lessons after school, and families spent an upward of $7,500 per month on private education for a single high school student, with 80 percent going to tutoring in the three core CSAT subjects: Korean, English, and Math. For English specifically, after being introduced to primary school curricula in 1997, the same year as the IMF crisis, as part of globalizing reforms, it became the fastest-growing market segment. Even this policy, initially aimed at social equity by bringing English to all levels of society including people from poorer backgrounds, only ended up spurring expenditure when those who could afford to tried to keep their competitive edge.

With the 1997 IMF crisis that resulted in mass privatization, deregulation, and layoffs, Korea was required to replace its traditional developmental-state economic model with a neoliberal one.[139] This furthered the role of education as a competitive hedge: after constant instances of the disappearance of lifetime employment and the bifurcation of the labor market, the credential that determined which side of the divide a worker landed on became more valuable, and investment in that credential by

[139] Kotz, David M., and Terrence McDonough, editors. *Neoliberalism and the Transformation of Capitalism in Korea*. PERI Working Paper Series, no. 67, Political Economy Research Institute, University of Massachusetts Amherst, 2004. https://peri.umass.edu/publication/item/182-neoliberalism-and-the-transformation-of-capitalism-in-korea

families with disposable resources increased accordingly.[140] Seen from the macro scale, Korean households spent around 20.2 billion dollars on private education in 2024, which was a 60.1% increase from 2014; this year was the fourth consecutive year of record spending. Moreover, for families with two unmarried children, average monthly private education spending stands at 611,000 won, 12.6% of total household expenditure, exceeded only by food.[141]

The trajectory from the 1980 ban to the post-IMF hagwon economy is a story of the state progressively withdrawing from the educational guarantees it had made, leaving families to absorb individually the competitive pressure that the system's structure continues to generate collectively. There are largely three overlapping withdrawals that constitute the structural shift: legal withdrawal with the Constitutional Court ruling removing the state's authority to prohibit private educational investment; economic withdrawal with the IMF crisis dismantling the lifetime employment model that had given the developmental state's human capital logic its social contract; and the progressive reframing of education from a public good the state delivers to a private investment families are responsible for making. These three withdrawals resulted in a public school system that cannot adequately prepare students for the CSAT without private supplementation, a private tutoring market that now consumes a record share of household budgets, and an inequality structure in which access to the best supplementary

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[140] Kim, Sunwoong, and Ju-Ho Lee. "Private Tutoring and Demand for Education in South Korea." *Economic Development and Cultural Change*, vol. 58, no. 2, 2010, pp. 259-296. University of Chicago Press, https://doi.org/10.1086/648186

[141] Yoo, Jee-ho. "Spending on Private Education Jumps 60% over Past Decade: Data." *The Korea Times*, 4 Jan. 2026, https://www.koreatimes.co.kr/amp/economy/20260104/spending-on-private-education-jumps-60-over-past-decade-data

education is increasingly determined by family income and geographic location.

Synthesis and Conclusion

Across the periods examined in this paper, including confucian examination culture, colonial bureaucratization, USAMGIK improvisation, the 1949 promise of mass schooling, the Korean War, foreign-aided reconstruction, and developmental dictatorship, the Korean education system has performed three functions with remarkable consistency: elite selection, labor allocation, and political control. The relative weight of each shifts by era, but the mechanism through which all three are accomplished, such as centralized gatekeeping, exam-mediated scarcity, and a credential hierarchy with a narrow apex, remains structurally continuous. The pyramid whose apex was Keijō Imperial University under colonial rule is the same pyramid whose apex is the SKY institutions today, rationalized by a different principle but producing a recognizably similar distribution. What changes across the periods is not the hierarchical output but the legitimating alibi: loyal imperial subjecthood, nationalist citizenship, developmental human capital, individual investment. The alibi changes, but the structure does not. This continuity explains what reform has consistently failed to grasp. Every intervention this paper has traced, such as the equalization policy, the hagwon ban, the emphasis on Susi, and the removal of killer questions, addressed the mechanism of competition without altering the incentive structure that makes competition rational. When the incentive structure is unchanged, competition migrates rather than diminishes. The gate moves but does not disappear. Calling the resulting intensity a product of Confucian culture performs a specific ideological function: it naturalizes the

phenomenon, locating its cause in an immutable inheritance rather than in a sequence of specific institutional decisions that can be identified, traced, and held to account. This paper has argued the opposite, arguing that the system was built, deliberately and incrementally, across a century of colonial rule, war, and authoritarian modernization, and that understanding it as such is the precondition for any reform that might actually work.

What sustains the system in its current form is rationality that goes beyond culture. University admissions in Korean society function almost as a kind of rite of passage. Korean high school students earn their placement in higher education through institutionalized processes such as the College Scholastic Ability Test (CSAT, or Suneung) and school rank. It is generally accepted that differences in demonstrated academic performance lead to differences in the universities students attend. Up to this point, the system itself is not necessarily problematic.

The more significant issue lies in the fact that, because graduation is relatively assured for most students once admitted, university diplomas carry different levels of social prestige depending on the institution's reputation. Traditionally, graduates of elite universities enjoyed advantages in employment, recruitment, and promotion opportunities. While the expansion of blind recruitment practices has reduced some of these effects by 2026, educational prestige continues to exert influence in many sectors. Given the substantial benefits associated with prestigious academic credentials, few people are willing to forgo the opportunity to compete for them without making a serious effort. A label acquired through examinations and university applications at around age twenty can continue to provide social and professional advantages throughout one's life. From this perspective, investing several years of effort in the admissions process may appear rational, even to those who recognize its shortcomings.

As a result, many people find themselves deeply committed to preparing for university entrance examinations despite believing that aspects of the admissions system and credentialism are unfair. The perceived long-term rewards attached to educational status make disengagement difficult, reinforcing the cycle of intense competition surrounding higher education. This is the trap that the paper's title names. The competitive logic is not irrational; it is individually rational and collectively self-defeating, sustained by the accumulated weight of a century of institutional decisions that made the credential hierarchy what it is. Reforming the examination without dismantling the hierarchy is the structural equivalent of changing the shape of the funnel while leaving its narrowness unchanged. What this paper has tried to demonstrate is that the funnel has a history that it was constructed through identifiable choices under identifiable pressures. Taking that history seriously is the only basis on which a different set of choices becomes imaginable.

Exploring Korean Education Through Students

Introduction

The formal structure of Korean education provides only a partial account of contemporary school life. A policy may formally expand students' course choices without ensuring that every school can offer the same range of classes, and because of the private tutoring-heavy nature of Korean education, which are largely underground or not tracked officially, the consequences of educational reform cannot be evaluated solely by examining official policy. Policy documents can measure formal arrangements, but student responses reveal what they actually perceive and how policies actually function in classrooms. They lack objectivity, but can help depict a picture of what their life is actually like. This section therefore examines Korean education from the perspective of the students currently living within it.

Even with the same national education system, Korean students do not necessarily experience high school in the same way: a student at a general high school may encounter different course options and admissions expectations from a student at a foreign-language, autonomous private, vocational, or Meister high school. Such schools differ in the resources available to them, the academic goals of their students, and the extent to which their programs are organized around university admissions[142], which

[142] Korean Education Centre UK. "Education in Korea." Korean Education Centre UK, Korean Embassy, https://koreaneducentreinuk.org/en/education-in-korea/.

may influence how they participate in class or allocate their time outside school, including how they use private education. However, it is important to note that school type alone does not determine every aspect of a student's experience; different students attending the same type of school or even the same school may differ based on their background, especially regional or familial, and intended future. Nevertheless, school type provides a useful starting point because it captures meaningful differences in institutional purpose and academic environment. The relevant question is therefore on which students it describes and which experiences it leaves out.

The aforementioned four types of high schools belong to a formal national classification system.[143] The divisions follow curricular purposes and institutional autonomy. There are generally four main types of high schools: general, special-purpose, specialized, and autonomous. Foreign-language schools belong to the special-purpose category, and most vocational or Meister schools belong to the specialized category in function, though Meister schools are legally classified as special-purpose schools. For the purpose of comparison, Meister schools will be classified as vocational schools.

General high schools are schools that provide education across a broad range of academic subjects. Their institutional purpose is relatively intuitive: completion of the national secondary curriculum and the preparation for university entrance that ensues, as well as providing a comparatively broad range of academic pathways. Such high schools enroll the largest and most varied student population, and thus, "general" does not mean uniform.

[143] Republic of Korea. "Enforcement Decree of the Elementary and Secondary Education Act." National Law Information Center, Ministry of Government Legislation, https://law.go.kr/법령/초ㆍ중등교육법시행령.

Course availability is vastly different depending on school size, location, staffing, and funding, with schools in affluent urban areas often offering more electives and advanced courses. The intensity of which students prepare for university admissions also differs substantially among schools.

Special-purpose high schools are schools created to provide advanced and concentrated education in a designated field. The fields of which such schools concentrate on include science, foreign languages, international studies, arts, and sports. Because these schools are so varied, they should not be treated as one socially or academically uniform group. Science, foreign-language, and international studies schools are more academically selective, with specialized subject requirements and strong university-admissions orientation, and student bodies are formed already concentrated around particular academic interests. Arts and sports schools offer specialized practical training and follow different schedules, assessment methods, and postsecondary pathways. Regardless, the broader category matters for this survey because students may have less freedom outside their specialization, which means their academic stress may come from specialized performance expectations rather than only the CSAT or university admissions, and the schools also may provide resources unavailable in ordinary general schools. These schools often have heavier workloads and more classes that follow the student-participatory model.

Specialized or vocational high schools were made for students that wanted preparation for employment in a particular occupational field by developing practical and technical skills. Such fields include engineering, information technology, tourism, culinary arts, and design. The general academic subjects remain present, but a substantial portion of instruction concerns practically applicable classes. A higher percentage of graduates thus seek

employment immediately, but some also go to universities or further vocational education.

Autonomous private high schools are defined by a greater discretion over curriculum and school operation. There is greater curricular and administrative independence, and are often selective or academically competitive. They are also commonly associated with preparation for prestigious universities, and may possess greater financial or institutional resources than ordinary schools. For the students' experience, they have broader or more distinctive course offerings and different admissions expectations, with more intensive academic competition in some schools and greater access to extracurricular or advanced academic programs.

Therefore, survey responses cannot automatically be treated as describing one uniform Korean high-school experience; differences between school types should be examined wherever the sample size permits.

This section examines how Korean high-school students currently experience several major dimensions of their education. The analysis focuses on four main things: the degree of control students believe they have over their course selections, whether students regularly encounter participatory models of class, the relationship between school instruction and private education, and students' well-being, examined through their available free time, reported academic stress, and principal sources of pressure. Together, these measures address a broader question of how differences in institutional settings implicate differences in students' daily academic lives. The analysis also considers whether different aspects of school life reinforce one another: students who feel a greater need for advancing their studies may spend more

time and resources on private education, while students with less discretionary time may report greater academic stress.

To investigate these questions, we conducted a survey of 63 students attending Korean high schools between September 13 and 17, 2026. Participants were recruited through schools and personal networks, and respondents were eligible if they were currently attending high school or had graduated within two years. Participation was also voluntary, and responses were collected anonymously. The survey asked students to report their own experiences, not evaluate their respective schools or Korean education as a whole. Most questions used response categories, allowing respondents to indicate degrees of what they experienced. Other questions asked for numerical ranges, such as weekly hours of private education or weekday free time. It is important to make explicit that the responses here measure students' perceptions of their educational environments, but do not independently verify the number of courses offered by each school, or objective criterion. This distinction matters because a student's perception may differ from what is objective, but at the same time, perceived experiences remain consequential because it influences how students spend their time and resources, especially for questions such as those concerning classroom comfort, perceived dependency, or academic pressure.

The resulting sample includes students from several school types, although those groups are not represented in equal proportions. Of the 63 valid responses, 31, or 49.2 percent, primarily attended foreign-language high schools. Students from autonomous private high schools formed the second-largest group, accounting for 15 respondents and 23.8 percent of the sample. The sample also included 8 students from general high schools, 5 from vocational or Meister high schools, and 1 from each of the following:

science/gifted high school, international high school, and international school. Table 1 reports the exact number and proportion of respondents in each category, while Figure 1 illustrates the distribution visually.

High School Type	Number of Respondents	Percentage of Respondents (%)
Foreign-language high school	31	49.2
Autonomous private high school	15	23.8
General high school	8	12.7
Vocational/Meister high school	5	7.9
Science/gifted high school	1	1.6
International high school	1	1.6
International school	1	1.6
Other	1	1.6

Table 1. Summary of Survey Respondents by school type (N=63)

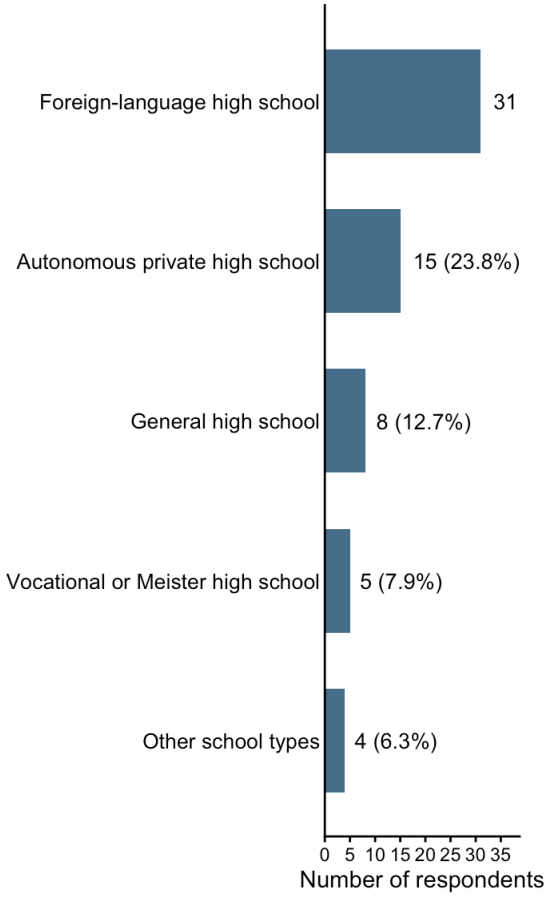


Figure 1. Distribution of survey respondents by primary school type (N = 63)

The distribution provides access to several distinct institutional settings but places particular weight on the experiences of students at selective or specialized schools. The data consequently offer stronger evidence about the school types most heavily represented than about categories with only a small number of respondents. Any comparison involving a small subgroup must be interpreted cautiously because a few responses can substantially

alter its percentages. The category therefore identifies each respondent's primary institutional experience.

This is a purposive, institutionally diverse sample rather than a representative sample of all Korean high-school students, since respondents were not selected through nationwide random sampling, and foreign-language and autonomous private high schools are represented at a substantially higher rate than they are in the national student population. Recruitment through personal networks and specific schools may also have reached students with similar academic interests or educational backgrounds. All participants were volunteers, which means those willing to complete a survey about education may differ from those who chose not to participate. The sample may also overstate experiences associated with academically selective or university-oriented environments, which may include high admissions pressure, extensive private education, or unusually strong exposure to discussion and project-based classes. Conversely, the experiences of students in general, vocational, rural, or less academically competitive schools may be underrepresented. The size of each subgroup also affects the reliability of comparisons: patterns based on 63 responses should not be interpreted with the same confidence as patterns based on a much larger group.

Although the survey cannot produce national estimates, its institutional diversity supports exploratory comparison: the sample is better suited to examining differences and relationships than to measuring national prevalence. Including respondents from several school types makes it possible to compare students who operate under different curricular purposes and academic expectations, and the relatively strong representation of foreign-language and autonomous private schools permits closer

examination of settings that may disappear into broader national averages. The survey also addresses experiences that are difficult to infer from official statistics, such as comfort asking questions or the anticipated consequences of stopping private education. These measures provide information about how students interpret the demands placed on them, even when they cannot independently establish the objective effectiveness of a school or policy. The purpose of the analysis is therefore not to construct a statistically 'average' Korean student, but to identify how educational experiences vary within a diverse, if uneven, group of students.

The survey questions can be understood as examining three connected levels of educational experience. The first level concerns the institutional conditions under which students study, including available curricular choice, prevailing teaching methods, and the admissions orientation of their schools. The second level concerns how students respond to those conditions, including whether they prepare material in advance, attend private education, participate in class, or devote additional time to academic work. The third level concerns the consequences students report, particularly restricted free time, academic stress, and dissatisfaction with specific aspects of the system. The analysis therefore focuses on patterns of association and interprets possible mechanisms cautiously. This framework treats academic pressure not as an isolated psychological condition but as an experience connected to how education is organized and how students respond to that organization.

The first two sections examine students' experiences within the formal school environment. The curriculum analysis begins with Question 2, which asks how much control students have over their course selections. Responses are compared across school types to determine whether formal

institutional differences correspond with different levels of perceived choice. Question 7 then asks how necessary students believe it is to study course material in advance. Cross-tabulating the two questions makes it possible to examine whether greater course choice is associated with a weaker or stronger perceived need for prior preparation. Course selection measures one form of autonomy, while the perceived necessity of advanced study measures a different constraint. A student may be free to select a subject but still feel unable to succeed in it without prior tutoring. The distinction prevents curricular choice from being treated as equivalent to educational independence. The next section examines how frequently students experience discussion, presentations, experiments, or project-based learning. These responses are compared with students' comfort asking questions during class.

The analysis then moves beyond the formal school day to examine private education. Weekly participation hours provide a measure of students' actual time commitment. Students' expected consequences of stopping private education provide a separate measure of perceived dependency. The distinction is necessary because extensive participation does not always mean that a student considers private education indispensable, while limited participation may reflect financial or practical constraints more than a lack of perceived need. The relationship between private-education hours and advanced study is also examined to determine whether the two practices form part of the same preparation pattern. Question 11 provides a broader policy perspective by showing how many respondents identify dependence on private education as an area requiring reform. The final section considers how these academic arrangements intersect with students' time and stress. Question 8 measures the amount of time students can use freely on weekdays after excluding sleep. Question 9 records students' self-assessed

academic stress. Comparing the two variables allows the analysis to examine whether respondents with less discretionary time also tend to report greater stress. Question 10 then identifies where students believe academic pressure originates. Separating the intensity of stress from its reported source makes it possible to distinguish students who experience similar levels of pressure for different reasons. Placed together, these questions connect institutional arrangements with the practical demands placed on students' time and the pressure they experience as a result.

This part begins from the proposition that contemporary Korean high-school life cannot be explained by a single national model. It investigates whether differences in school type are accompanied by differences in curricular autonomy, classroom participation, private-education use, and academic pressure. It also examines whether these dimensions operate independently or appear to reinforce one another. The results are interpreted as patterns within the sample rather than definitive national conclusions. Before interpreting these relationships, it is necessary to establish who participated in the survey. The composition of the sample determines both the comparisons that can be made and the limits placed on their interpretation. The following profile therefore presents respondents by school type before the analysis turns to differences in curriculum, instruction, private education, and academic pressure.

Differences in Curriculum and School Operations

Course choice is one form of control over a student's education, but it does not necessarily determine what happens after a course begins. A student may choose a subject that interests them and still believe they must learn its

material before the teacher introduces it. The distinction matters because a policy that expands course selection may change students' schedules without changing the academic demands they experience with those courses. Question 2 of our survey asks respondents how much choice they perceive in selecting their courses. Question 7 asks how necessary respondents believe it is to study course material in advance. The two questions measure different experiences: perceived control over course selection and perceived need for preparation before instruction. Neither question measures the number of courses a school offers, the difficulty of those courses, or the amount of advanced study students actually complete. Comparing the responses allows us to test a limited proposition: students who report greater course choice might also report less need to prepare ahead. The proposition is plausible because students with more choice may be better able to select courses suited to their interests or prior knowledge. The opposite is also plausible: students may choose demanding courses precisely because those courses serve their academic goals. The survey can identify whether the two ratings move together within this group of respondents, but it cannot determine why any relationship appears or fails to appear.

Responses to Question 2 were spread across the lower and middle portions of the five-point scale. Twelve of the 63 respondents (30.2 percent) selected 2, making it the most common answer. Eighteen respondents (28.6 percent) selected 3. Thirteen respondents (20.6 percent) selected 4, while only one respondent (1.6 percent) selected 5. Taken together, 31 respondents (49.2 percent) selected 1 or 2, compared with 14 respondents (22.2 percent) who selected 4 or 5. The distribution suggests that substantial perceived control over course selection was uncommon among these respondents. A rating of 3 should not automatically be interpreted as satisfaction with course choice; it identifies a position on the response scale without explaining why the

student selected it. The ratings also cannot establish whether students faced a small course catalogue, timetable conflicts, required courses, or other restrictions. A school could formally offer several electives while an individual student still experiences limited choice because the available courses conflict with one another. Conversely, a student might report considerable choice within a relatively small programme if its offerings meet their interests. The survey therefore captures a consequential part of school operations as students experience it, while leaving the specific source that experience unresolved. A frequency table should report all five Q2 categories, including the single response at 5, so the distribution remains visible without collapsing it into a simple 'choice' or 'no choice' divide.

Perceived course choice varied across the school types represented in the survey, although the groups differed substantially in size. Among the 31 foreign-language high-school respondents, 10 selected 1, six selected 2, 11 selected 3, and four selected 4; none selected 5. Sixteen of the 31 foreign-language high-school respondents (51.6 percent) therefore rated their course choice at 1 or 2. Among the 15 autonomous private high-school respondents, one selected 1, six selected 2, seven selected 3, and one selected 4. Seven of these 15 respondents (46.7 percent) rated their course choice at 1 or 2. The eight general high-school respondents gave a different set of answers: one selected 1, one selected 3, five selected 4, and one selected 5. Six of the eight general high-school respondents rated their course choice at 4 or 5, compared with four of 31 foreign-language high-school respondents and one of 15 autonomous private high-school respondents. All five vocational or Meister high-school respondents selected 2. These figures show variation within the sample, but the general and vocational groups are too small to support confidential claims about their school types as a whole. The particularly high ratings among the eight general high-school respondents

should not be interpreted as evidence that general high-schools generally offer students more curricular choice. Nor should the lower ratings among some respondents at selective schools be interpreted as a direct measure of those schools' course catalogues. School type identifies an institutional setting, while Question 2 records an individual student's perception within that setting. The subgroup results give the overall course-choice distribution more texture without turning this voluntary sample into a national comparison of school systems. A compact supplementary table could show each school type's respondent count and Q2 distribution, while the prose should concentrate on the groups large enough to discuss consciously.

Question 7 produced a distribution concentrated around the middle and upper portions of its five-point scale. No respondent rated the perceived need for advance study at 1. Eight respondents (12.7 percent) selected 2, and 30 (47.6 percent) selected 3. Fifteen respondents (23.8 percent) selected 4, while 10 (15.9 percent) selected 5. Twenty-five of the 63 respondents (39.7 percent) thus rated the need for advance study at 4 or 5. The predominance of 3 does not establish that most students regarded advance study as either indispensable or unnecessary. The absence of ratings at 1 is narrower but clear: no student in this sample chose the lowest available rating for perceived necessity. Question 7 concerns students' judgments about what they need to do, going beyond a record of how many hours they spend studying ahead. A student who regards advance study as necessary may have little time or money to pursue it. Another student may study ahead regularly without believing it is essential for success. The distinction between perceived necessity and actual behavior becomes especially relevant when the book later examines private education. The present section should therefore describe a perceived academic demand without treating it as a direct measurement of tutoring participation. Among foreign language

high-school respondents, 12 of 31 rated advance-study need at a 4 or 5. The corresponding counts were six of 15 autonomous private high-school respondents, five of eight general high-school respondents, and one of five vocational or Meister high-school respondents. These subgroup counts suggest that a high perceived need for advance study was not confined to one school type in the sample. Differences between the small groups remain uncertain because a change of one or two responses would substantially alter their percentages. A separate frequency table should report every Q7 category so readers can distinguish the large middle group from respondents who chose the upper ratings.

A cross-tabulation places each respondent's course-choice rating beside their advance-study rating. An inverse relationship would appear if higher course-choice rating beside their advance-study rating. An inverse relationship would appear if higher course-choice ratings tended to coincide with lower advance-study ratings. The responses do not show a consistent movement in that direction. Among the 12 respondents who rated course choice at 1, five rated advance-study need at 33, four rated it at , and three rated it at 5. Among the 19 respondents who rated course choice at 2, three rated advance-study need at 2, eight rated it at 3, three rated it at 4, and four rated it at 5. The sole respondent who rated course choice at 5 also rated advance-study need at 5. That single response cannot establish a pattern at the top of either scale. Grouping Q2 ratings for a simpler comparison produces similar proportions at the upper end of Q7. Of the 31 respondents who rated course choice at 1 or 2, 12 (38.7 percent) rated advance-study need at 4 or 5. Of the 14 respondents who rated course choice at 4 or 5, six (42.9 percent) rated advance-study need at 4 or 5. The difference between 38.7 and 42.9 percent is small and should not be presented as evidence that greater choice increases the need for advanced study. The grouped

comparison is intended to make the cross-tabulation easier to read; the correlation provides a fuller assessment of the ordering of individual responses. The cross-tabulation should remain in the section even though it yields no striking pattern, because it allows readers to inspect the responses behind the statistical summary.

Spearman's rank correlation was used because both questions asked respondents to select ordered ratings. The correlation between course choice and perceived need for advance study was $\rho = -0.0638$ across all 63 responses. The negative sign indicates the direction of the measured association, but its magnitude is so small that the responses show virtually no monotonic relationship. The raw ρ value was 0.6192. The Benjamin-Hochberg adjusted ρ value was 0.6859 when this comparison was considered alongside the wider set of correlations examined in the survey analysis. The result provides no persuasive evidence, within this sample, that respondents who perceived more course choice also perceived less need for advance study. It would be inaccurate to describe the result as proof that course choice has no effect on students' preparation. A correlation examines how two reported ratings vary together; it does not test the effect of changing a school's curriculum. The analysis cannot distinguish a genuinely weak relationship from a relationship obscured by the sample size, composition, or the broad response categories. It also cannot reveal whether different relationships exist within particular school types, because several of the school-type groups contain very few respondents. The result should be stated plainly rather than concealed because it does not support the initial expectation. A finding near zero helps identify which assumptions about school life the available evidence does not justify. The statistical claim should remain narrow: the survey did not detect a clear association between these two perceived experiences among its respondents.

The findings separate two forms of educational autonomy that are easy to conflate. Course selection concerns whether students can influence the subjects appearing on their schedules. The perceived need for advance study concerns whether students believe ordinary instruction is sufficient preparation for those subjects. A student can experience the first form of control while continuing to feel constrained by the demands of the second. One possible explanation is that students select courses according to long-term academic goals and then prepare ahead because those same goals make performance important. Another possibility is that the pace or difficulty of a chosen course creates demand for preparation regardless of whether the student chose it freely. A further possibility is that students' views of advance study reflect explanations beyond any particular course. These explanations are hypotheses, because Questions 2 and 7 did not ask respondents why they selected courses or why they felt preparation was necessary. The two questions also rely on self-reported perceptions, not independent records of course offerings, enrollment rules, classroom pacing, or study time. The respondents were recruited voluntarily through schools and personal networks. Foreign-language and autonomous private high-school students account for 46 of the 63 responses, so their experiences carry considerable weight in the overall result. The introductory survey profile explains this imbalance in the detail; the present section needs only to remind readers that its figures describe the sample, not the national student population. The finding cannot evaluate whether giving students more course choice is desirable for reasons other than reducing the perceived need to study ahead. It does indicate that course choice should not be treated as a sufficient measure of how much freedom students experience in their academic lives. Within this group of respondents, greeter perceived course choice did not reliably accompany a lesser perceived need for advance study.

Understanding that result more fully would require evidence about the courses students could choose, the expectations inside those courses, and the reasons students felt compelled to prepare before instruction.

Differences in Teaching Methods and Student Participation

A classroom can contain discussions, presentations, experiments, or projects without every student feeling comfortable speaking in it. These activities create opportunities to participate, but the presence of an opportunity does not tell us how students experience it. Some may find it easier to ask questions in a class where their contributions are expected. Others may participate when required while remaining reluctant to reveal that they do not understand something. This section examines both aspects of classroom life: how often respondents report encountering participatory teaching and how comfortable they feel asking questions.

Question 3 asked respondents about the frequency of participatory class models, including discussions, presentations, experiments, and project-based learning. Question 4 asked how comfortable they felt asking questions during class. Higher ratings indicate more frequent participatory teaching or greater comfort, respectively. The questions are related, but they do not measure the same thing. Question 3 concerns the activities students encounter; Question 4 concerns their willingness to speak up when they need an answer. A student could give a high rating to one and a low rating to the other without contradicting themselves.

Participatory teaching received relatively high ratings among the 63 respondents. One student (1.6 percent) selected 1, 12 (19.0 percent) selected

2, and 13 (20.6 percent) selected 3. Thirty-four respondents (54.0 percent) selected 4, making it the most common answer, while three (4.8 percent) selected 5. In total, 37 respondents (58.7 percent) chose 4 or 5, compared with 13 (20.6 percent) who chose 1 or 2. The responses suggest that participatory activities were familiar to many students in this sample. They do not show how much class time those activities occupied or whether students found them useful.

The concentration at 4 requires care in interpretation. It would be easy to describe these answers as evidence that the respondents' classrooms were predominantly student-led. The survey did not ask students to estimate the proportion of time spent on lectures, group work, experiments, or presentations, and its single rating combines several activities that can work differently in practice. A presentation may require students to speak at length but offer little room to ask spontaneous questions. An experiment may involve active work without much whole-class discussion. The Q3 distribution establishes that many respondents reported comparatively frequent exposure to participatory models; it does not describe a single, uniform teaching method.

Comfort asking questions was more evenly distributed. Seven respondents (11.1 percent) rated their comfort at 1, 11 (17.5 percent) selected 2, and 19 (30.2 percent) selected 3. Seventeen students (27.0 percent) selected 4, while nine (14.3 percent) selected 5. Twenty-six respondents (41.3 percent) therefore selected 4 or 5, fewer than the 37 who gave participatory teaching an upper rating. Another 18 respondents (28.6 percent) rated their comfort at 1 or 2. Even in a sample where participatory activities were commonly reported, a substantial number of students did not describe themselves as particularly comfortable asking questions.

The difference between the two distributions should not be read as a count of students whose classes were participatory but who felt unable to speak. The totals for Q3 and Q4 summarize separate questions, and only a cross-tabulation can show how each respondent answered both. The difference does, however, identify a reason to examine the questions together. The availability of activities that call for student involvement does not, by itself, establish that students feel at ease raising their own uncertainties during class.

The cross-tabulation shows a positive relationship, though it is not perfectly orderly. Among the 37 respondents who rated participatory teaching at 4 or 5, 20 (54.1 percent) also rated their comfort asking questions at 4 or 5. Among the 26 respondents who rated participatory teaching at 1, 2, or 3, six (23.1 percent) rated their comfort at 4 or 5. Low comfort ratings show a corresponding difference: six of the 37 respondents (16.2 percent) in the higher participatory-teaching group rated their comfort at 1 or 2, compared with 12 of the 26 respondents (46.2 percent) in the lower group. Students who reported more participatory teaching were thus more likely, within this sample, to report feeling comfortable asking questions.

The individual response categories make that pattern more concrete. Of the 34 respondents who selected 4 for participatory teaching, 11 selected 4 for question comfort and seven selected 5. Ten selected 3, while six selected 1 or 2. By contrast, among the 13 respondents who selected 3 for participatory teaching, only two rated their comfort at 4 or 5. The 12 respondents who selected 2 for participatory teaching gave a wider range of comfort ratings, including four at 4. The sole respondent who selected 1 for participatory teaching also selected 1 for comfort. These counts show why the overall

relationship is best described as a tendency rather than a rule governing individual experiences.

Spearman's rank correlation between the two ratings was $\rho = 0.3786$ across all 63 responses, with a raw p value of 0.0022. The positive coefficient indicates that respondents who rated participatory teaching more highly tended to rate their comfort asking questions more highly as well. When the comparison is considered alongside the wider set of correlations examined in this survey, its Benjamini–Hochberg adjusted p value is 0.0466. The association remains below the 0.05 threshold after that adjustment. Its size is moderate rather than overwhelming: the responses support a relationship, but they leave considerable variation in how individual students experience participatory classes.

This is one of the clearer associations in the survey, but correlation does not identify its cause. Participatory activities might help students become accustomed to speaking in front of their classmates. Teachers who make questions welcome might also be more likely to use discussion and group work, creating both experiences at once. Students who already feel comfortable speaking may perceive a class as more participatory because they take greater part in its activities. The survey cannot distinguish among these explanations. It asked students to rate their experiences at one point in time and did not observe their lessons, track changes in comfort, or establish which experience came first.

The school-type breakdown adds another qualification. Among the 31 foreign-language high-school respondents, 20 rated participatory teaching at 4, and none selected 5. Yet only eight of the 31 rated their comfort asking questions at 4 or 5. Six students in this group rated participatory teaching at 4 while rating their own comfort at 1 or 2. These are individual responses, not merely a contrast between two separate totals. They demonstrate that

relatively frequent participatory activities and low comfort asking questions can coexist for the same student.

Among the 15 autonomous private high-school respondents, eight rated participatory teaching at 4 or 5, and eight rated question comfort at 4 or 5. Six gave upper ratings to both. The eight general high-school respondents produced a different distribution: only one rated participatory teaching at 4, while three rated their comfort asking questions at 4 or 5. Four of the five vocational or Meister high-school respondents gave upper ratings to both questions. These figures describe the respondents in each category, but the general and vocational groups are too small to support conclusions about those school types as a whole. They also should not be treated as estimates of differences between Korean schools, since students within a school type may attend different schools and take different classes.

The foreign-language high-school responses are particularly useful for interpreting the overall correlation. Across the full sample, more participatory teaching tended to coincide with greater comfort asking questions. Within the largest school-type group, however, many students reported participatory teaching without giving their comfort an equally high rating. The two findings are compatible. A positive association across 63 respondents does not imply that every classroom activity creates the same experience for every student. It also does not mean that a high Q3 rating is interchangeable with a high Q4 rating.

The distinction matters because “participation” can refer to several different demands on a student. Giving a prepared presentation, contributing to assigned group work, answering when called on, and asking an unprompted question all involve speaking, but they require different kinds of initiative. A

student may be willing to deliver a presentation after rehearsing it while hesitating to interrupt a lesson to admit confusion. Question 3 groups several participatory formats into one rating, while Question 4 isolates one specific action: asking questions. The survey cannot tell us which class activities are most closely related to comfort, but it gives us reason to avoid treating all forms of participation as equivalent.

Comfort also depends on more than the formal design of a lesson. Question 4 records each respondent's own judgment, which may reflect experiences with particular teachers, subjects, classmates, or courses. The survey did not ask students to identify which of those circumstances shaped their answer. Its findings therefore cannot establish that changing a teaching method alone would change students' willingness to ask questions. They do show that the social experience of speaking in class deserves attention alongside the list of activities a curriculum or teacher provides.

Both measures have further limits. Students may understand "participatory teaching" differently, especially when the question includes activities as varied as experiments and presentations. A single comfort rating may also average over classes in which a student behaves differently. A respondent might freely ask questions in one subject and avoid doing so in another. Because the survey relies on self-reports, it cannot verify how often participatory activities occurred or count the questions students actually asked. These limitations narrow the claims that can be made from the responses; they do not erase the reported association between the two experiences.

The sample composition places an additional boundary around that claim. Foreign-language and autonomous private high-school respondents account

for 46 of the 63 responses. The introduction explains how participants were recruited and why the sample cannot represent Korean high-school students nationally. The result here should therefore be understood as a pattern among the respondents rather than a national estimate of classroom participation or speaking comfort. Nor does this Korea-focused survey, on its own, establish a difference between Korean and American classrooms. That comparison requires evidence from both settings.

Within these limits, the section points to a precise conclusion. Respondents who reported more frequent participatory teaching generally felt more comfortable asking questions, and the association remained statistically detectable after adjustment for the survey's multiple correlation tests. The relationship was incomplete: some students encountered participatory activities often while remaining uncomfortable speaking up. Classroom participation is consequently worth examining both as an instructional practice and as a student experience. Asking students to take part creates an opportunity; their answers show whether that opportunity feels usable to them.

Differences in Private Education

The survey asked 63 respondents how much time they spent each week in private education or individual tutoring. Thirty-two students (50.8 percent) reported ten hours or more. Ten (15.9 percent) reported six to under ten hours, another ten (15.9 percent) reported three to under six hours, and three (4.8 percent) reported less than three hours. Eight students (12.7 percent) reported no private education that week. In total, 55 respondents (87.3 percent) reported some participation, and 52 (82.5 percent) reported

at least three hours. For half of this sample, private education occupied ten or more hours outside school each week. The question records time spent, but it does not show what subjects students studied, how much their families paid, or whether the instruction improved their academic results.

Students were also asked what they thought would happen to their schoolwork or admissions preparation if they stopped receiving private education. Thirty respondents (47.6 percent) expected to be substantially disadvantaged, and 22 (34.9 percent) expected to be somewhat disadvantaged. Seven (11.1 percent) expected almost no effect, three (4.8 percent) thought their situation would improve, and one (1.6 percent) selected the option stating that they did not currently receive private education. Thus, 52 of the 63 respondents anticipated some disadvantage. These answers describe students' expectations about a hypothetical change. They do not measure what would actually happen if a student stopped attending tutoring.

The distinction is clearer when the responses are limited to the 55 students who reported spending some time in private education that week. Fifty of them (90.9 percent) expected stopping to disadvantage them: 30 anticipated a substantial disadvantage and 20 a slight one. Two expected almost no effect, while three expected an improvement. Among the eight students who reported no private-education hours, five expected almost no effect, two anticipated a slight disadvantage, and one selected "I do not currently receive private education." The two questions therefore do not divide respondents into identical groups. A student reporting no hours in a particular week could still express a view about the possible consequences of going without private education.

Cross-tabulating weekly hours with expected consequences shows how those views differed across participation levels. Of the 32 students reporting ten hours or more, 19 expected to be substantially disadvantaged if they stopped and ten expected to be somewhat disadvantaged. One expected almost no effect, and two expected an improvement. All ten students in the six-to-under-ten-hour category anticipated a disadvantage, as did all ten in the three-to-under-six-hour category. Responses were more varied among the three students reporting less than three hours: one expected a slight disadvantage, one expected almost no effect, and one expected an improvement. The smaller groups contain too few students to support broad claims about how expectations change with each additional hour. The larger groups nevertheless show that many respondents who devoted substantial time to private education also believed that stopping would put them at a disadvantage. The survey cannot establish whether that belief reflects an academic benefit, fear of falling behind, or another reason. Private-education hours had a weak relationship with students' perceived need to study course material before it was taught at school. Using the original responses, Spearman's correlation between weekly hours and perceived need for advance study was $\rho = 0.119$ ($p = 0.353$; Benjamini–Hochberg adjusted $p = 0.585$ across the 21 reported correlations). The data do not provide clear evidence that students who spent more time in private education also felt a greater need to prepare school lessons in advance. Even within the ten-or-more-hours group, responses varied: 13 of the 32 students selected one of the two strongest levels of advance-study need, while 16 described it as somewhat necessary and three said it was not very necessary. Private education and advance study are related aspects of preparation, but the questions do not establish that students used their tutoring hours to prepare upcoming school lessons.

The reform-priority question provides a separate measure of how students viewed private education. Twenty-four respondents (38.1 percent) selected high dependence on private education as an area of Korean high-school education needing improvement. Among these 24 students, 15 also selected excessive competition between students, 14 selected excessive academic workload, and 12 selected an emphasis on tests and grades. Because respondents could choose multiple areas, these figures describe overlapping concerns. They also measure something different from the question about stopping tutoring: expecting a personal disadvantage does not necessarily mean selecting private-education dependence as a reform priority.

The survey contains no direct question about clubs, sports, arts, volunteering, or other extracurricular activities. It therefore cannot show whether private education reduced students' participation in those activities or how students valued them. The evidence in this section concerns reported tutoring time, anticipated consequences of stopping, and students' views on educational reform.

Exploring Korean and U.S. Education Through Policy

The survey shown above provides a detailed account of how students experience modern Korean high-school education. However, in order to understand the significance of these experiences, it is prudent to take a look at the structures and practices of the Korean and American education systems in general. This section, thus, attempts to compare how the two systems currently structure students' academics, highlighting both major differences and similarities. Since neither country has one unified system of education, this study looks at variations among the types of schools and districts, curriculum, courses, and individual schools.

The survey and interviews serve to complement and not override this analysis. While official sources can articulate the organization of each system, they may not fully illustrate the ways in which policies play out in daily student life. Accounts from students, however, can illuminate the former by describing the impact of policies on the students' choices in curriculum, classroom involvement, tests, college admissions, private schooling, and extracurricular activities. These accounts are not treated as representative of either country. Instead, they are used to illustrate, reinforce, or complicate patterns identified through broader evidence.

The comparison will be structured around five areas: the curriculum and organization of schools; methods of teaching and levels of participation; tests, grades, and evaluation; college admissions; and private education and extracurricular activities. Within each section, the analysis moves from a

description of the organization of each system, to a comparison of the two systems, and then to an illustration of the ways in which policies affect students, using survey and interview responses.

Differences in Curriculum and School Operations

By the media or the perceptions of many, the difference between Korean and American classrooms boils down to a teacher directed versus student centered approach to education. While it is true that this is the difference many students have seen and experienced, it should not be seen as a definitive binary. Both countries encourage communication, cooperation and participation among students and both countries have extensive variations among teachers, subjects, schools, and courses.[144] In reality, the more interesting differences lie in how common these participatory activities are, what form they take and how students respond to them.

In Korea, the national curriculum has been shifting, more and more, towards student centered, communicative, collaborative, creative, and individualized activities. The Ministry of Education asserts that the 2022 Revised National Curriculum seeks to help students to be more driven and self motivated to adapt to the changing world of society and technology. Even more recently, implementation guidelines have emphasized

[144] Republic of Korea Ministry of Education, "Outline of 2022 Revised Curriculum," December 1, 2021, https://english.moe.go.kr/boardCnts/viewRenewal.do?boardID=254&boardSeq=89791&lev=0&m=0202&opType=N&page=1&s=english; Common Core State Standards Initiative, *Common Core State Standards for Mathematics*, 6–7, https://corestandards.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/09/Math_Standards1.pdf; Next Generation Science Standards, "Three-Dimensional Learning," https://www.nextgenscience.org/three-dimensional-learning.

communication, collaboration, and learner centered activities.[145] This shows a policy shift within Korean education that acknowledges the importance of discussion, projects, and active learning. With that said, even if these initiatives have been introduced, they require much from the educators in terms of balancing multiple objectives for a given class. There is the issue of class sizes, unique requirements for different subjects, limited teaching hours and the pressure to prepare students for difficult exams. This results in an extended period of transition before the ideal system can be fully implemented.

The United States does not have an official national curriculum, but there are educational standards that are widely accepted and followed.[146] The focus tends to be on students defending their answers, accommodating other perspectives, and generally collaborating. For example, Common Core Standards for Mathematical Practice require students to critique the reasoning of others and ask clarifying questions to form more valid conclusions.[147] The Next Generation Science Standards regard inquiry,

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[145] Republic of Korea Ministry of Education, "[Ministry of Education Notice No. 2022-33] National Curriculum for Elementary and Secondary Schools," December 22, 2022, https://www.moe.go.kr/boardCnts/viewRenew.do?boardID=141&boardSeq=93458&lev=0; Republic of Korea Ministry of Education, "2022 Revised National Curriculum for Primary, Secondary and Special Schools Announced," January 2, 2023, https://english.moe.go.kr/boardCnts/viewRenewal.do?boardID=265&boardSeq=93810&lev=0&m=0201&opType=N&s=english&statusYN=W.

[146] U.S. Department of Education, "Federal Role in Education," https://www.ed.gov/about/ed-overview/federal-role-in-education; U.S. Department of Education, "Frequently Asked Questions: Elementary and Secondary Education," https://www.ed.gov/about/contact-us/faqs/Elementary%20and%20Secondary%20Education.

[147] Common Core State Standards Initiative, *Common Core State Standards for Mathematics*, 6–7, https://corestandards.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/09/Math_Standards1.pdf.

modeling, argumentation from evidence, and problem-solving as critical components of learning science.[148]

Consistent with these standards, classrooms in American schools tend to have more debates, presentations, questions, and group work. With that said, it is still entirely dependent on the teacher, subject, level of education, and student body. This is not to say that these practices are not done in other countries, it is simply that the US educational system emphasizes these strategies.

As a consequence, the interviews tended to reflect this preoccupation with participation. Students who were enrolled, or who had previously attended schools in both countries shared similar impressions of American teachers being more approachable and American students being more inquisitive, talkative, and forthcoming even when they did not have the correct answers. They felt it was safer to make mistakes in class in the US because they would be less likely to be ridiculed or judged by their peers. However, the interviews also showed that it was not always the case in American classrooms. Students who had the opportunity to experience different types of classes and settings noted that it was largely dependent on the teacher, level of the class, and general atmosphere of the class. There were some students who were more willing to participate than others, while some classes were more lecture based. Thus, although many educational standards

[148] NGSS Lead States, *Next Generation Science Standards: For States, By States*, Appendix F, "Science and Engineering Practices in the NGSS," 2013, https://www.nextgenscience.org/sites/default/files/Appendix%20F%20%20Science%20and%20Engineering%20Practices%20in%20the%20NGSS%20-%20FINAL%20060513.pdf.

in the U.S. emphasize student participation, the extent to which it occurs varies by state, district, school, course, and teacher.[149]

Differences in Teaching Methods and Student Participation

In the media or in many people's perspectives, the contrast between Korean and American classrooms is often described as a difference between teacher-directed and student-centered education. However, even though it is true that this distinction captures part of the difference reported by students, it should not be treated as an absolute division. Both countries promote communication, problem-solving, and participation skills for students, and both have substantial variation among teachers, subjects, schools, and levels of courses. In fact, the more interesting difference may be in how often students run into these participatory activities, how they are structured, and how students feel about participating.

In Korea, the national curriculum has tended to focus more and more on student-centered, communicative, collaborative, creative, and individualized activities. The Ministry of Education states that the 2022 Revised National Curriculum aims to develop students to be more motivated and self-directed so that they can adapt to the challenges of society and technology. Even more recent implementation guidelines stress the importance of

[149] U.S. Department of Education, "Federal Role in Education," https://www.ed.gov/about/ed-overview/federal-role-in-education; Common Core State Standards Initiative, "Frequently Asked Questions," https://www.thecorestandards.org/about-the-standards/frequently-asked-questions/

communication, collaboration, and learner-centered activities.[150] This suggests that there is indeed a trend towards including discussions, projects, and active learning in Korean schools. At the same time, even if the initiatives have been introduced in many schools, they require teachers to balance diverse demands related to class sizes, subject-specific requirements, time available for classes, and the need to prepare students for exams, which means that it can take time to fully implement the intended system.

The United States does not have a single national curriculum, but widely accepted academic standards tend to require students to defend their answers and consider others' points of view. For instance, Common Core Standards for Mathematical Practice demand that students critique their peers' reasoning and formulate questions that improve the validity of their solutions.[151] Similarly, the Next Generation Science Standards treat investigation, modeling, evidence-based argument, and problem-solving as essential scientific practices rather than optional classroom activities.[152] Therefore, a classroom in American schools tends to contain more debates, speeches, inquiries, and group work. However, this does not mean that these practices are present in every classroom. It depends on the teacher, discipline, level of education, resources provided, and students' needs. So, a classroom may still be mostly based on lectures in certain circumstances.

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[150]Republic of Korea Ministry of Education, "Outline of 2022 Revised Curriculum," December 1, 2021, https://english.moe.go.kr/boardCnts/viewRenewal.do?boardID=254&boardSeq=89791&lev=0&m=0202&opType=N&page=1&s=english.

[151]Common Core State Standards Initiative, "Common Core State Standards Initiative," accessed September 30, 2026, https://corestandards.org/.

[152]Next Generation Science Standards, "Three-Dimensional Learning," accessed September 30, 2026, https://www.nextgenscience.org/three-dimensional-learning.

Consequently, the interviews tended to reflect this focus on observable participation. Students who attended schools in both countries described American teachers as more accessible and American students as more inquisitive, talkative, and forthcoming, even when they were uncertain of the correct answer. They thought that it was safer to make mistakes in class in the United States because they felt less likely to be laughed at or judged by classmates. However, the interviews revealed that this was not always the case in American classrooms. Students who had the experience of attending different kinds of classes reported that it all depended on the teacher, the level of the course, and the dynamics of the class. Student participation depended heavily on the students taking the class, as some groups of students were more willing to speak, ask questions, and engage with one another than others, whereas some classes are more lecture-oriented. Thus, even though many of the educational standards in the U.S. tend to stress the need for more student participation in the learning process, the degree to which this is practiced still varies from state to state, district to district, school to school, course to course, and teacher to teacher.

Test, Grades, and Assessment Systems

Assessment in Korea and the United States involves several distinct processes: evaluating classroom work, recording academic achievement, and administering external examinations. These processes should be distinguished because a classroom assignment, a transcript grade, and a standardized test score do not necessarily measure the same abilities or serve the same purposes. The comparison therefore concerns how achievement is measured, how results can be compared, and what consequences those measurements have for students.

Korean high-school assessment includes both written examinations and performance assessments, rather than relying exclusively on conventional tests. Performance assessments may involve presentations, written tasks, projects, or practical activities, depending on the subject and the school's assessment plan. Official school-record guidance identifies the proportions of written and performance assessment, performance-assessment categories, and achievement cutoffs as information provided for university admissions.[153] A distinction must also be made between achievement levels and relative grades: the former describe performance against specified criteria, while the latter indicate a student's position within an assessed group. These measures answer different questions, since demonstrating competence does not necessarily mean outperforming classmates.

Korea is undergoing a change in its high-school grading system, making it necessary to identify which rules apply to which students. Students entering high school in 2025 fall under the reformed framework associated with 2028 university admission, which replaces the previous nine-band relative grading system with five bands. Relative grading is not universal within this framework: the finalized reform excludes social and science convergence electives from relative rank-grade reporting.[154] Consequently, students surveyed in 2026 may have experienced different grading rules, and their responses should not automatically be interpreted as reactions to one uniform system.

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[153] 학교생활기록부 종합지원센터. Response to "수행평가 영역명 관련하여 파이썬 문구 사용 가능 여부." 학교생활기록부 종합지원포털, 17 Apr. 2025, star.moe.go.kr/web/contents/m30103.do?id=77149&schM=view. Accessed 10 Oct. 2026.

[154] Ministry of Education, Republic of Korea. "2028 입시부터 국어.수학.사회.과학 선택과목 없는 통합형 수능, 내신 5등급 체제 확정." 교육부, 27 Dec. 2023, www.moe.go.kr/boardCnts/viewRenew.do?boardID=294&boardSeq=97551&lev=0. Accessed 10 Oct. 2026.

In the United States, classroom grading policies are determined within state, district, and school frameworks, rather than through one national grading formula. Course grades may incorporate examinations, papers, projects, and other assessed work, although their weighting and the opportunities for reassessment vary. For example, Fairfax County Public Schools publishes district rules governing reassessment, grade replacement, and late work, illustrating how local policies shape the meaning of a grade.[155] Grade point averages summarize course results, while weighted systems may assign additional value to designated advanced courses. Fairfax County, for instance, awards additional GPA weighting for honors courses.[156] A GPA therefore needs to be interpreted alongside the school's grading scale and course offerings, rather than treated as a nationally uniform measurement.

External examinations provide another form of academic evidence, but their role should be distinguished from the grades students receive in school. Korea's CSAT is closely connected to university selection, although its importance depends on the admission route and institution. In the United States, standardized admissions testing is governed by differing institutional policies rather than one requirement followed by every university. Yale currently requires standardized testing within its broader review process, whereas the University of California excludes SAT and ACT scores from

[155] Fairfax County Public Schools. "Middle and High School Grading and Reporting Handbook." Fairfax County Public Schools, www.fcps.edu/academics/grading-and-reporting/secondary-school. Accessed 10 Oct. 2026.

[156] Fairfax County Public Schools. "FCPS Postsecondary Profile." Fairfax County Public Schools, www.fcps.edu/about-fcps/leadership/district-performance-transparency/postsecondary-profile. Accessed 10 Oct. 2026.

comprehensive review.[157][158] These examples show why the presence of standardized testing should not be confused with exclusive reliance on it.

Assessment rules can influence what students consider necessary for academic success. Where relative standing matters, improving one's own understanding may not be sufficient to secure a higher grade if classmates improve as well. Where course grades accumulate across multiple tasks, students may need to sustain performance over an extended period rather than concentrate their preparation on a single examination. These are possible incentives created by assessment structures, rather than proof that every student responds in the same way. The survey's reports of academic pressure and advance preparation can illustrate students' experiences, but cannot establish that a particular grading policy caused them. The central comparison concerns the balance between comparable results, varied opportunities to demonstrate learning, and the discretion given to individual schools.

Differences in College Admissions Systems

University admissions in Korea and the United States involve different combinations of academic results, institutional requirements, and judgments about applicants. Neither country can be described accurately through a single admission method. The comparison therefore concerns

[157] Yale University. "Standardized Testing." Undergraduate Admissions, admissions.yale.edu/standardized-testing. Accessed 10 Oct. 2026.

[158] University of California Board of Regents. "Regents Policy 2102: Policy on Undergraduate Admissions." Board of Regents, amended 21 July 2022, regents.universityofcalifornia.edu/governance/policies/2102.html. Accessed 10 Oct. 2026.

which evidence universities consider, how that evidence is combined, and how selection requirements influence students' preparation.
Korean university admissions are commonly organized into susi and jeongsi recruitment periods, but these categories should not be treated as two entirely uniform selection methods. Susi includes routes centered on school grades, comprehensive school-record review, university essay examinations, and practical or performance-based assessment. School-grade-centered and comprehensive school-record routes must be distinguished because calculating academic results differs from evaluating a broader record of school learning. Some susi routes also require applicants to meet minimum CSAT results, so school-record review and external examinations may operate together. Jeongsi is predominantly CSAT-centered, although university-specific requirements can incorporate other evidence.[159] Seoul National University's 2027 jeongsi documentation, for example, includes curricular evaluation within a CSAT-centered route, demonstrating that the recruitment period does not necessarily imply selection by examination scores alone. [160]

At U.S. institutions using holistic review, universities assess academic records alongside other information about the applicant. Depending on the institution, application requirements may include essays, recommendations, activities, and standardized test scores in addition to transcripts.[161] Academic

[159] Educational Broadcasting System. "2027/28 대입시행계획." EBSi, cloud-www.ebsi.co.kr/ebs/ent/enta/retrieveUnivEntOperPnt.ebs?yearGbn=2022. Accessed 10 Oct. 2026.
[160] Seoul National University Office of Admissions. "2027학년도 대학 신입학생 정시모집 '나'군 안내." 서울대학교 입학본부, 28 Aug. 2026, admission.snu.ac.kr/undergraduate/notice?bbsidx=174665&md=v. Accessed 10 Oct. 2026.
[161] Common App. "Application Guide for First-Year Students." Common App, www.commonapp.org/apply/first-year-students/. Accessed 10 Oct. 2026.

achievement remains central to this process, rather than becoming unimportant because additional information is considered. Yale's admissions guidance identifies academic strength as a primary consideration and interprets applicants' records within their educational circumstances.[162] The University of California similarly considers grades and course selection in the context of the applicant's school.[163] These examples describe particular institutions and should not be treated as a universal model for all American universities.

U.S. universities differ in whether standardized admissions tests are required, optional, or excluded from consideration. A test-optional policy allows applicants to decide whether to submit scores, while a test-free policy excludes those scores from admission review. Required testing can coexist with holistic review, as Yale's current policy demonstrates.[164] The University of California provides a contrasting example because SAT and ACT scores are excluded from its comprehensive review process.[165] Testing policies must therefore be identified by institution and application year.

A useful comparison concerns how clearly applicants can identify the relationship between their qualifications and the selection decision.

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[162] Yale University. "What Yale Looks For." Undergraduate Admissions, admissions.yale.edu/what-yale-looks-for. Accessed 10 Oct. 2026.

[163]University of California. "How the University of California Evaluates Student Applications." University of California, 7 Oct. 2026, www.universityofcalifornia.edu/news/how-the-university-of-california-evaluates-student-applications. Accessed 10 Oct. 2026.

[164] Yale University. "Standardized Testing." Undergraduate Admissions, admissions.yale.edu/standardized-testing. Accessed 10 Oct. 2026.

[165] 1. University of California Board of Regents. "Regents Policy 2102: Policy on Undergraduate Admissions." Board of Regents, amended 21 July 2022, regents.universityofcalifornia.edu/governance/policies/2102.html. Accessed 10 Oct. 2026.

Published score calculations can make particular parts of admission more predictable, but they do not establish that applicants have equal access to preparation. Broader review can incorporate circumstances that a numerical result omits, while leaving applicants less certain about the relative importance of different accomplishments. Korean comprehensive school-record admission also requires interpretation, making discretion a feature of both countries' systems. Neither numerical selection nor broader review can therefore be assumed to be fairer without defining fairness and examining actual admission outcomes.

Admission requirements can influence students' decisions well before they submit an application. Students may allocate time toward examinations, course performance, or other experiences according to what their intended admission route rewards. A broader set of application components can create additional ways to demonstrate achievement, but can also expand the range of tasks applicants feel obliged to complete. These are possible consequences of selection structures, rather than findings established by the survey. Student interviews can illustrate how particular applicants understand those demands, while the Korea-focused survey cannot independently establish a difference between the two countries. The relevant issue is how admission rules shape students' perceptions of what a successful education requires.

Differences in Private Education and Extracurricular Activities

Education and extracurricular activities play an integral role in students' daily lives and experiences.. They are both available in South Korea and the

United States but differ significantly in terms of objectives, organization, and importance to students' academic performance. The main distinction, therefore, is the allocation of students' time to academics and extracurricular activities and whether such activities and education are privately purchased or provided by schools.

In Korea, private education is most often associated with hagwons, tutoring, online courses, and test-prep institutions that provide supplementary education beyond the standard school curriculum. Based on the official 2025 survey, 75.7 percent of primary, middle, and high-school students in Korea attended a private educational institution for an average of 7.1 hours per week.[166] Amongst high-school students who participated in private education, the average monthly cost of such education was 793,000 South Korean Won.[167] This shows that private education plays a significant role in the academic life of a Korean student. Yet, the participation rate and expenditure on private education depends on a student's socio-economic status, regional location, grade level, and educational needs.[168]

In the United States, private tutoring, educational centers, and test-prep programs also exist, but private education tends to play a smaller role in

[166] Ministry of Data and Statistics, Republic of Korea, "Private Education Expenditures Survey of Elementary, Middle and High School Students in 2025," March 12, 2026, https://mods.go.kr/board.es?act=view&bid=11758&list_no=444220&mid=a20111020000.

[167] Hyunjoon Park and Youngshin Lim, "Student Participation in Private Supplementary Education: A Comparative Analysis of Japan, Korea, Shanghai, and the USA," *Chinese Journal of Sociology* 6, no. 2 (2020): 239–256, https://doi.org/10.1177/2057150X20916011.

[168] National Center for Education Statistics, "Average Start Time and Percentage Distribution of Start Time for Public Secondary/High Schools, 2020–21," https://nces.ed.gov/surveys/ntps/estable/table/ntps/ntps2021_srt04_s1s; National Center for Education Statistics, "Average Daily Attendance, School Day Length, and School Year Length," https://nces.ed.gov/programs/digest/d14/tables/dt14_203.90.asp.

students' everyday lives than in Korea.[169] Some students seek help in paying for tutoring for school challenges, enrichment, or college entrance exams, but it is typically not considered an essential accessory to public education. Also, since the American schools tend to end by mid-afternoon, many students engage in sports, after-school clubs, music, community service, jobs, or other extracurricular activities instead of education outside of school.[170] However, access to private education and extracurricular activities tends to differ according to family income, location, school availability, and students' own ambitions just like in Korea.

Extracurricular activities are organized differently within the two systems. Korean schools offer clubs, student government, career programs, and creative experiential activities, some of which are part of the official curriculum and academic transcript. There is considerable variation among schools regarding the range of activities and the degree to which students have control over them, and academic commitments can be a limiting factor affecting the time that students can devote to such activities. In American schools, extracurricular activities are much more likely to include sports teams, performing arts, student government, service organizations, and interest-based clubs, with students often organizing and running their own clubs with the school's approval.[171] This structure creates more opportunity for leadership roles and sustained involvement, though the opportunities

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[169] Korean Ministry of Education, "Regulations on the Preparation and Management of School Records," Ministry of Education Directive No. 555, Article 13, effective March 1, 2026, https://star.moe.go.kr/web/contents/m20103.do?id=108056&schM=view.

[170] National Center for Education Statistics, "Back-to-School Statistics," https://nces.ed.gov/fastfacts/display.asp?id=372.

[171] National Association for College Admission Counseling, "Factors in the Admission Decision," https://www.nacacnet.org/factors-in-the-admission-decision/.

still depend to a large extent on the school's resources, location, staff, and student body.

The purposes of these activities also vary from each other. In Korea, private education is usually meant to raise student's academic abilities, prepare them for tests (mainly school exams or CSAT), or to enable students to learn materials that are beyond their current level. Activities that are provided in schools, on the other hand, focus on collaboration, exploring possible careers, and community service. Extracurricular activities in the United States are more done to satisfy one's interests, participate in their communities, and engage in leadership activities. Moreover, they are significant for getting into college, especially if the college has a holistic review, meaning that they review all information about the applicant. Students might participate in extracurricular activities for different reasons, just like in Korea, where the main motivation might be getting into college, having good grades, or for both educational and social reasons.

Labor

Education and the Transition into Employment

One of the most direct ways in which education influences an individual's economic opportunity is through its relationship with employment, as formal qualifications can affect both access to particular occupations and the likelihood of obtaining work. Across OECD countries, individuals with higher educational attainment generally experience lower unemployment rates, although the strength of this relationship varies considerably between national labor markets. In the United States, for example, the Bureau of Labor Statistics reported that unemployment among bachelor's degree holders aged 25 and older was 2.5% in 2024, compared to 4.2% among high school graduates, suggesting a substantial association between higher education and employment prospects. However, the OECD's examination of Korean youth employment suggests that high levels of educational attainment do not necessarily guarantee a smooth transition into work, particularly when graduates encounter difficulties finding positions that correspond to their expectations and qualifications. Therefore, comparing the relationship between education and employment in South Korea and the United States requires examining not only whether individuals obtain jobs, but also how educational qualifications interact with recruitment practices, labor market conditions, and the availability of suitable employment.[172]

[172] U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics. "Education Pays, 2024." Career Outlook, May 2025, https://www.bls.gov/careeroutlook/2025/data-on-display/education-pays.htm.

Although both South Korea and the United States have highly educated populations, the relationship between educational attainment and unemployment differs considerably between the two countries. According to the OECD's Education at a Glance 2025, 4.3% of tertiary-educated Koreans aged 25-34 were unemployed in 2024, compared to 4.4% of those with upper-secondary or postsecondary non-tertiary qualifications and 4.6% of those without an upper-secondary qualification. In the United States, by contrast, the corresponding unemployment rates were 2.9%, 5.7%, and 8.9%, respectively, according to the most recent year available for the American series in the same OECD report, 2023. These figures suggest that additional educational attainment is associated with a much stronger reduction in unemployment among young adults in the United States than in South Korea, where unemployment rates differ relatively little across educational categories. This relationship is also reflected in the broader American workforce, where BLS data for 2024 indicate that unemployment generally decreases as educational attainment increases. Nevertheless, these differences should not be interpreted as direct measurements of the causal effects of education, since individuals with different qualifications may also differ in work experience, family background, occupational preferences, and other characteristics that influence employment[173].

Apart from differences in employment rates, the transition from education into employment is shaped by the institutions that connect graduates with

[173] Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD). "Korea." Education at a Glance 2025, 9 Sept. 2025, https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/education-at-a-glance-2025_1a3543e2-en/korea_252c9ed2-en.html. See also OECD, "United States," Education at a Glance 2025, 9 Sept. 2025, https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/education-at-a-glance-2025_1a3543e2-en/united-states_784df67f-en.html, fig. 2 and table A3.5.

potential employers and determine how educational qualifications are evaluated during recruitment. In South Korea, the OECD has identified company recruitment examinations, supplementary employment preparation, and competition for positions in desirable firms as important factors influencing the length and character of young people's school-to-work transitions. The Korea Employment Information Service's Graduates Occupational Mobility Survey provides evidence on this transition by following university graduates' educational experiences, employment preparation, first jobs, and subsequent movements within the labor market. In the United States, the National Center for Education Statistics similarly examines graduates' early employment outcomes through the Baccalaureate and Beyond Longitudinal Study, which tracks employment status, further education, earnings, and occupational characteristics after graduation. American universities may facilitate employment through internships, career services, and employer recruitment arrangements, although the availability and effectiveness of these opportunities vary across institutions and academic disciplines. Consequently, the principal difference between the two countries should not be understood as one between an exclusively examination-based Korean system and an exclusively experience-based American system, since both incorporate formal qualifications, practical experience, and employer-specific selection procedures. Rather, their school-to-work transitions should be compared according to how these arrangements influence the speed, accessibility, and quality of graduates' entry into employment[174].

[174] Korea Employment Information Service. "GOMS (Graduates Occupational Mobility Survey)." Employment Survey, https://survey.keis.or.kr/eng/goms/goms01.jsp. See also OECD, OECD Economic Surveys: Korea 2024, OECD Publishing, 2024, https://doi.org/10.1787/c243e16a-en.

However, the difficulties associated with entering the workforce cannot be understood solely through graduates' educational qualifications, since the structure of the labor market also influences the opportunities available to them. In South Korea, the labor market is characterized by a distinction between regular and non-regular employment, alongside considerable differences in compensation, employment security, and working conditions between large corporations and smaller enterprises. These differences can encourage graduates to compete for positions in large corporations and public institutions, where expected employment benefits may justify prolonged preparation for selective recruitment processes. Consequently, some graduates may choose to postpone entering the workforce if their offers have less favorable compensation or working conditions. This suggests that Korea's competitive educational environment may be sustained partly by differences in the quality of available employment opportunities, going beyond just the cultural importance attached to academic achievement[175].

The United States also exhibits considerable differences in employment security and working conditions, although these differences are organized through somewhat different institutional arrangements. While employment-at-will generally allows private-sector employers greater discretion in terminating employment, contractual protections, collective bargaining agreements, and occupational regulations can provide varying degrees of security for particular groups of workers.Furthermore, American graduates' employment opportunities differ considerably across industries, with professional occupations offering different prospects for compensation and career advancement than many service-sector positions. Consequently, both countries exhibit inequalities in job quality, but the extent to which

[175] Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development. OECD Economic Surveys: Korea 2024. OECD Publishing, 11 July 2024, https://doi.org/10.1787/c243e16a-en.

these inequalities affect graduates' initial employment decision depends on their respective labor market institutions. This comparison suggests that educational qualifications cannot be evaluated independently of the employment arrangements and occupational opportunities they allow individuals to access[176].

Educational Attainment and Financial Returns

Beyond improving employment opportunities, education also influences individuals' earning potential, making the relationship between educational attainment and wages an important measure of its economic value. This relationship is commonly examined through the college wage premium, which refers to the earnings advantage associated with completing higher education compared to individuals with lower educational qualifications. In both South Korea and the United States, university graduates generally earn more than individuals whose highest qualification is a high school diploma, although the magnitude of this difference varies considerably between the two countries. However, the financial benefits of education cannot be determined solely by comparing average wages, since employment rates, working hours, occupational differences, and the costs of education also influence individuals' economic outcomes[177].

Despite their similarly high levels of educational attainment, South Korea and the United States differ in the extent to which additional education is

[176] Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development. OECD Employment Outlook 2024. OECD Publishing, 2024, https://doi.org/10.1787/ac8b3538-en. For cross-country variation in employment protection and labor institutions.

[177] U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics. "Education Pays, 2024." Career Outlook, May 2025, https://www.bls.gov/careeroutlook/2025/data-on-display/education-pays.htm.

associated with higher earnings. According to the OECD, the relative earnings advantage associated with tertiary education is generally greater in the United States than in South Korea, indicating that the financial rewards attached to educational qualifications differ between the two labor markets. One possible explanation lies in differences in wage structures, as the distribution of earnings across occupations and educational groups influence how much additional compensation university graduates can expect. Furthermore, Korea's extensive expansion of higher education has increased the supply of university graduates, potentially reducing the scarcity of tertiary qualifications and placing greater importance on differences between institutions, academic disciplines, and individual skills. Nevertheless, differences in average wage premiums do not necessarily establish that one country's universities provide more valuable education, since labor market institutions and the characteristics of degree holders also influence observed earnings.[178]

The financial returns to higher education also differ substantially among graduates within the same country, suggesting that educational attainment alone is an insufficient predictor of future earnings. Graduates entering occupations such as engineering, medicine, and certain technical professions may receive considerably different compensation from those entering education, social services, or other comparatively lower-paying sectors. These differences reflect not only the skills acquired through particular academic programs, but also occupational demand, licensing requirements, and the compensation structures of different industries. Institutional

[178] Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development. "What Are the Earnings Advantages to Education?" Education at a Glance 2025, OECD Publishing, 2025, https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/education-at-a-glance-2025_1c0d9c79-en/full-report/what-are-the-earnings-advantages-to-education_7a7e64e0.html, tables A4.1–A4.2.

reputation may additionally influence earnings by affecting graduates' access to selective employers, recruitment networks, and professional opportunities. Consequently, assessing the financial value of higher education requires distinguishing between the returns associated with completing a degree, studying a particular discipline, and attending a particular institution, rather than treating university graduates as a homogeneous group.[179]

However, differences in earnings among university graduates cannot necessarily be attributed entirely to differences in the knowledge and skills acquired through education. According to human capital theory, education can increase workers' productivity by developing their abilities, whereas signaling theory suggests that educational qualifications can also communicate information about applicants' underlying characteristics to employers. Since employers cannot directly observe every applicant's future workplace performance, university degrees and institutional reputations may serve as screening mechanisms during recruitment. Consequently, graduates of prestigious institutions may receive employment advantages partly because of employers' expectations concerning their abilities, not in relation to because their education had not made them more productive. Nevertheless, the observed advantages of prestigious universities may also reflect differences in students' prior academic preparation, access to professional networks, and recruitment opportunities, making it difficult to isolate the independent effect of institutional reputation. Thus, the financial value of a qualification depends on how employers interpret and reward

[179] Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development. "What Are the Earnings Advantages to Education?" Education at a Glance 2025, OECD Publishing, 2025, https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/education-at-a-glance-2025_1c0d9c79-en/full-report/what-are-the-earnings-advantages-to-education_7a7e64e0.html.

those qualifications within labor markets, going further than the skills it represents[180].

Although higher education can increase future earnings, obtaining additional qualifications also requires substantial investments of time and financial resources. As discussed in the Economics section, the distribution of educational expenditure differs between South Korea and the United States, with Korean families devoting substantial resources to supplementary education and American students often facing significant university tuition costs. However, an individual's educational investment also involves opportunity costs, particularly the earnings that could have been obtained by entering the workforce rather than spending additional years in education. The financial return to a degree therefore depends on whether its expected earnings advantages are sufficient to compensate for tuition, living expenses attributable to studying, foregone income, and any interest paid on educational loans. Moreover, these calculations involve uncertainty, since graduates' eventual earnings depend on economic conditions, individual career trajectories, and whether they obtain employment corresponding to their qualifications.[181]

Ultimately, higher education attainment is associated with improved earning potential in both countries, but the magnitude of these benefits depends on factors extending beyond the number of years individuals spend in school. While differences in national wage premiums provide insight into the average financial value associated with educational attainment, they conceal

[180] Spence, Michael. "Job Market Signaling." The Quarterly Journal of Economics, vol. 87, no. 3, Aug. 1973, pp. 355–74, https://doi.org/10.2307/1882010.

[181] Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development. "United States." Education at a Glance 2025, OECD Publishing, 9 Sept. 2025, https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/education-at-a-glance-2025_1a3543e2-en/united-states_784df67f-en.html.

substantial variation between graduates pursuing different academic and professional pathways. Furthermore, the observed earnings advantages of university graduates cannot be attributed entirely to education itself, since individuals entering higher education may already differ in academic preparation, socioeconomic background, and other characteristics affecting their labor market outcomes. Thus, understanding why certain educational qualifications generate greater financial rewards requires examining how employers evaluate academic credentials and determine which applicants possess the skills necessary for particular positions. This relationship between educational qualifications, employer recruitment practices, and workplace requirements forms the basis of the following section.

Education and Socioeconomic Mobility

Beyond its influence on employment opportunities and individual earnings, education is frequently regarded as a mechanism of socioeconomic mobility, allowing individuals to improve their economic circumstances relative to those of their families. This relationship is particularly significant in South Korea and the United States, where educational achievement has historically been associated with the possibility of obtaining employment and social status beyond those available to previous generations. However, socioeconomic mobility encompasses two distinct concepts: absolute mobility, which refers to improvements in economic circumstances across generations, and relative mobility, which concerns whether an individual's position within the economic hierarchy becomes less dependent on the family background. Consequently, rising educational attainment and higher average earnings do not necessarily indicate greater equality of opportunity, particularly if individuals from more advantaged families continue to

occupy disproportionately favorable positions within the labor market. Evaluating education's contribution to mobility therefore requires examining whether these benefits reduce the influence of socioeconomic background on their subsequent opportunities.[182]

Although both countries have substantially expanded access to higher education, individuals' chances of obtaining educational qualifications remain associated with their parents' socioeconomic circumstances. According to the OECD's Education at a Glance 2025, 85% of Koreans aged 25-34 with at least one tertiary-educated parent had completed tertiary education themselves, compared to 45% of those whose parents had not completed upper-secondary education. This 40-percentage-point difference demonstrates that even within a country characterized by exceptionally high overall educational attainment, parental educational background remains strongly associated with children's educational outcomes. In the United States, research by economist Raj Chetty and his colleagues found that children from families in the highest 1% of the income distribution were 77 times more likely to attend Ivy League colleges than those from families in the bottom income quintile. Although these indicators measure different forms of educational advantage and cannot be compared directly, they demonstrate how socioeconomic background can influence access to educational opportunities in both cities.[183]

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[182] Chetty, Raj, et al. "Mobility Report Cards: The Role of Colleges in Intergenerational Mobility." National Bureau of Economic Research, working paper no. 23618, July 2017, https://doi.org/10.3386/w23618.

[183] Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development. "Korea." Education at a Glance 2025, 9 Sept. 2025, https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/education-at-a-glance-2025_1a3543e2-en/korea_252c9ed2-en.html, fig. 1. See also Chetty, Raj, et al., "Mobility Report Cards: The Role of Colleges in Intergenerational Mobility," NBER working paper no. 23618, July 2017, https://doi.org/10.3386/w23618.

Nevertheless, differences in educational attainment represent only one mechanism through which socioeconomic advantages can be transmitted between generations. Even among individuals with similar academic qualifications, family resources may influence access to internships, professional networks, geographic relocation, and the financial support necessary to pursue selective employment opportunities. For example, graduates from wealthier households may be better positioned to undertake unpaid internships or postpone employment while preparing for competitive recruitment processes, whereas those facing immediate financial obligations may have fewer such options. These differences suggest that academic qualifications do not necessarily eliminate inequalities in the resources available to individuals during their transition into the labor market. However, research on American colleges by Chetty also found that students from lower- and higher-income families attending the same institution often achieved similar earnings outcomes, suggesting that access to particular educational institutions can provide meaningful opportunities for disadvantaged students. Therefore, the relationship between family background and employment should not be understood as entirely predetermined, since educational institutions can both reproduce existing inequalities and provide opportunities to overcome them.[184]

This raises broader questions about educational meritocracy, particularly the assumption that academic achievement provides individuals with opportunities primarily determined by their abilities and efforts. In principle, educational qualifications can reduce the influence of inherited

[184] Chetty, Raj, et al. "Mobility Report Cards: The Role of Colleges in Intergenerational Mobility." National Bureau of Economic Research, working paper no. 23618, July 2017, https://doi.org/10.3386/w23618. See especially the results on earnings conditional on college attended.

social status by allowing employers to evaluate applicants according to demonstrated achievement, not family background. But when access to educational resources and prestigious institutions is itself influenced by socioeconomic circumstances, ostensibly meritocratic selection procedures may reproduce advantages that existed before individuals entered the labor market. This tension is evident in both countries, although the institutional mechanisms through which educational advantages are acquired and converted into employment opportunities may differ.[185] Consequently, the effectiveness of meritocratic education should be evaluated by whether individuals from different socioeconomic backgrounds have comparable opportunities to achieve and benefit from those qualifications.

Ultimately, education remains an important potential pathway toward socioeconomic advancement in both South Korea and the United States, but its ability to reduce inherited inequality is constrained by the relationship between educational opportunities and labor market institutions. As discussed in the preceding sections, additional educational attainment is associated with improved employment prospects and higher earnings, although these benefits differ according to occupational demand, institutional reputation, and employment arrangements. Furthermore, the persistence of socioeconomic differences in educational attainment and access to selective institutions suggests that formal educational achievement cannot be evaluated independently of the circumstances under which it is obtained. Nevertheless, these limitations do not negate education's capacity to facilitate upward mobility, particularly when disadvantaged students can

[185] Chetty, Raj, et al. "Mobility Report Cards: The Role of Colleges in Intergenerational Mobility." National Bureau of Economic Research, working paper no. 23618, July 2017, https://doi.org/10.3386/w23618.

access institutions and qualifications associated with favorable employment outcomes. Rather, they suggest that the effectiveness of education as a mechanism of individual advancement depends on both the opportunities available within educational institutions and the labor market structures that determine how educational achievement is rewarded. The following Economics section considers their broader implications for economic growth, public expenditure, and the distribution of resources across society.

Economics

Economic Effects of Education in South Korea and the United States

Not only does the education system of a country affect the quality of life of its citizens, but it also impacts the economy. On the one hand, it provides human capital in the form of enhanced knowledge and skills for the labor market. On the other hand, it creates an enormous financial burden on the government and the population. Even though some similarities in the economies of South Korea and the United States have been discussed in the previous paragraph, this section will focus on the different effects of the two countries' education systems on their respective economies. Despite the considerable investment in education in both countries, the financial burden is manifested differently in terms of accessibility and economic growth.

Human Capital, Productivity, and Economic Growth

One of the most crucial economic functions of education is the accumulation of human capital, the stock of knowledge and skills that enables people to productively contribute to the economy. A nation with well-educated citizens is likely to have the capacity to adapt to technological advances, create more sophisticated products and services, and successfully navigate economic transitions.[186] However, the economic importance of

[186] World Bank, "Human Capital," https://www.worldbank.org/en/publication/human-capital.

education goes beyond years of schooling and numbers of degrees, diplomas, and certificates. It encompasses the quality and relevance of the acquired skills, the ability to constantly acquire new ones, and the accessibility of education to ensure that the entire population realizes its latent human capital. In that respect, education contributes most to economic growth when extended knowledge is combined with enhanced capacities.
Education was a critical factor in transforming South Korea from a war-torn developing nation into a wealthy and technologically advanced country. The expansion of secondary and postsecondary education increased the pool of skilled labor that fueled South Korea's economic take-off and the rise of electronics, automobile, engineering, and technology sectors.[187] The OECD highlights the role of the education system in Korea's economic miracle, as growing educational attainment levels contributed to the nation's rapid economic growth over the last five decades.[188] At present, South Korea maintains one of the highest levels of educational attainment globally. In 2025, 58 percent of the working-age population in South Korea possessed a tertiary education, compared to the OECD average of 43 percent, and only 1 percent of Koreans aged 25-34 had not completed upper secondary education.[189] Such high levels of educational attainment demonstrate Korea's ability to build human capital effectively.

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[187] World Bank, "Republic of Korea," https://www.worldbank.org/ext/en/country/korea. www.worldbank.org

[188] Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development, "Executive Summary," *OECD Economic Surveys: Korea 2026*,
https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/oecd-economic-surveys-korea-2026_6b87f585-en/full-report/executive-summary_4d2a0ce1.html.

[189] Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development, "Education at a Glance 2026: Korea," https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/education-at-a-glance-2026_c0e523a9-en/korea_5e4f6d39-en.html. www.oecd.org

Nevertheless, elevated levels of education do not necessarily translate into increased human capital. The OECD expresses concerns about the South Korean education system in that it emphasizes rote memorization and examination skills rather than fostering self-education and lifelong learning.[190] This issue manifests itself in the low levels of participation in non-formal education and training. Only 16 percent of employed Koreans aged 25-44 participated in non-formal education and training in 2025, compared to the OECD average of 52 percent, and 15 percent of employed people aged 45-64, compared to 45 percent on average across OECD nations.[191] The concern is justified, as the requirements for knowledge and skills change over time, particularly with the advent of new technologies and processes. Thus, while the South Korean education system effectively increased the share of the population with tertiary education, its effectiveness in enhancing human capital now faces challenges.

The United States is another country with high levels of education attainment, albeit with a different approach to education. In 2025, 52 percent of working-age Americans possessed a tertiary education, which exceeded the OECD average, and the share of young adults without upper secondary education dropped from 10 percent in 2015 to 5 percent in 2025.[192] Furthermore, the U.S. education system fuels America's innovation

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[190] Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development, "Smarting Up Education and Lifelong Learning," *OECD Economic Surveys: Korea 2026*, https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/oecd-economic-surveys-korea-2026_6b87f585-en/full-report/smarting-up-education-and-life-long-learning_707e5ccd.html.

[191] Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development, "Education at a Glance 2026: Korea," https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/education-at-a-glance-2026_c0e523a9-en/korea_5e4f6d39-en.html.

[192] Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development, "Education at a Glance 2026: United States," https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/education-at-a-glance-2026_c0e523a9-en/united-states_d412b71f-en.html.

edge through research and development activities conducted in American universities. For instance, American colleges and universities spent an estimated 117.7 billion dollars on research and development in fiscal year 2024, which reflects an 8.1 percent increase in current dollars compared to the previous year.[193] Accordingly, American universities are not only centers of learning but also of innovation and economic development. Consequently, the education systems of the two countries differ in their approaches to education, which affects the ways in which they have accumulated human capital. Korea has leveraged its high levels of educational attainment to create a pool of human capital with a strong general education. The United States has combined high levels of education with a broad array of academic and professional degrees and an extensive network of research and development facilities that have fueled innovation and technology advances. Nevertheless, the potential of educational systems to enhance human capital and economic growth is not predetermined. Both nations must ensure that their education systems are not wasteful of the available resources. In Korea, the challenge is to transform examination-oriented and paper qualifications into skills that are relevant across a lifespan. In the U.S., the challenge is to ensure that the economic and innovative potential of the education systems is not concentrated among the elite at the expense of the general population.

[193] National Center for Science and Engineering Statistics, "Universities Report 8.1% Growth in R&D Expenditures in FY 2024, Reaching Over $117 Billion," February 10, 2026, https://ncses.nsf.gov/pubs/nsf26305. ncses.nsf.gov.

Public and Private Education Spending

Education requires significant expenditures, but the economic impact varies based on the source of funding and the efficiency of its utilization. State spending on schools and colleges increases the educational opportunities and human capital of the population across society, whereas private spending on education increases the educational opportunities of some individuals while also entailing higher opportunity costs for those individuals. Education spending has positive economic effects but also involves opportunity costs because resources dedicated to tuition, tutoring, or other educational expenditures can not be allocated to consumption, saving, residences, or other forms of investments.

South Korea is characterized by extensive state spending on formal education combined with exceptionally high private expenditures on supplementary education. In 2023, South Korea's government expenditure on educational institutions (primary, secondary, and tertiary education) amounted to 4.1% of GDP, while private expenditure on educational institutions (excluding additional spending on private tutoring) accounted for another 0.8%.[194] The latter figure does not reflect all private tutoring expenditures outside educational institutions. Time spent learning in private tutorials by Korean students is extensive, with households spending, according to the official 2025 survey, around 27.5 trillion won on private education for elementary, middle, and high-school students. Thus, the average monthly spending amounts to 458,000 won per student in the whole student population and 604,000 won per student in those who

[194] Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development, "Education at a Glance 2026: Korea," https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/education-at-a-glance-2026_c0e523a9-en/korea_5e4f6d39-en.html.

undergo private tutoring.[195] Such expenditures may enhance the educational opportunities of individuals, but they also involve significant opportunity costs for students' families. The perceived need to spend more on private tutoring to keep up with peers can lead to further increases in expenditures on education without a proportional increase in societal knowledge and human capital.

The US provides a different education system, where the cost of education is distributed differently. While in 2022, government expenditure on primary, secondary, and tertiary education in the US also amounted to approximately 5% of GDP, private expenditure on educational institutions only accounted for 0.6% of GDP.[196] Meanwhile, the financing of education is highly decentralized in the US. Thus, in the 2022-23 school year, American public elementary and secondary schools had a revenue of around $981.8 billion, out of which 12.9% was allocated as the federal government's share, 45.1% was provided by state governments, and 42% was allocated by local governments (with property taxes being the main source of revenue for school districts).[197] Therefore, the distribution of revenues in the US education system is highly dependent on the wealth of states and local governments within the federal framework. American households,

[195] Ministry of Data and Statistics, Republic of Korea, "2025 Survey of Private Education Expenditures for Elementary, Middle, and High School Students," March 12, 2026, https://mods.go.kr/board.es?act=view&bid=245&list_no=443953&mid=a10301010000.

[196] Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development, "Education at a Glance 2026: United States," https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/education-at-a-glance-2026_c0e523a9-en/united-states_d412b71f-en.html.

[197] National Center for Education Statistics, "Revenues for Public Elementary and Secondary Schools, by Source of Funds and State or Jurisdiction: School Year 2022–23," https://nces.ed.gov/programs/digest/d25/tables/dt25_235.20.asp.

therefore, experience different educational expenditures depending on the state where they reside.

American households tend to have fewer private educational expenditures on elementary, secondary, and tertiary education than Korean households, but significantly higher expenditures on higher education. The average annual tuition fees for domestically domiciled bachelor's students at public institutions in the US amounted to around $9,596, while the average at private institutions was $34,041. Thus, around 82% of students receive a subsidy in the form of grants, scholarships, public loans, or government-guaranteed private loans.[198] Educational finance differs significantly across the two countries, with American households facing significantly higher expenditures on education during higher education than during primary education or secondary education. Hence, American households will experience a significant consumption decrease (and the opportunity cost of their expenditures on education) during higher education, whereas Korean families will experience the highest expenditures during secondary education. However, the economic efficiency of such education expenditures depends on whether increased expenditures result in higher educational opportunities and human capital than in the case of the alternative education system.

[198] Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development, "Education at a Glance 2025: United States," https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/education-at-a-glance-2025_1a3543e2-en/united-states_784df67f-en.html.

Inequality and Social Mobility

Education can advance social mobility by enabling students to acquire skills and qualifications irrespective of their family background, but it can also reproduce economic inequality if access to education depends on family income, location, or inherited advantages. On a macroeconomic level, unequal education is not only a social concern but also an economic one: by preventing capable students from accessing the resources they need to develop their talents, societies deny themselves the productivity and innovation those students might contribute. In South Korea, the issue of equal opportunity in education is particularly acute due to the sheer volume of private education. Students from more prosperous households can afford to invest much more in their academic potential, and they often do. In 2025, pupils from families with a monthly income of over 8 million won spent 662,000 won on private education per month, compared to 192,000 won among students from families with a monthly income of under 3 million won. The proportion of students who participated in private education was 84.9% and 52.8%, respectively, among the two groups. The gap between the two was also considerable in terms of location: whereas Seoul residents spent 663,000 won on private education per student per month, people from rural towns and townships only managed 325,000 won.[199] This does not necessarily prove that private education influences academic outcomes, but the fact remains that more affluent and urbanized families can afford to buy considerably more educational resources than those who are less well-off. This disparity does not appear to affect overall levels of education in South Korea, where tertiary education is already widespread. Among Koreans aged

[199] Ministry of Data and Statistics, Republic of Korea, "Private Education Expenditures Survey of Elementary, Middle and High School Students in 2025," March 12, 2026, https://mods.go.kr/board.es?act=view&bid=11758&list_no=444220&mid=a20111020000.

25 to 34 with at least one tertiary-educated parent, 85% had completed tertiary education, compared to 45% among those who did not complete upper secondary education.[200] The forty-percentage-point gap is still considerable, and while equal opportunity in education would clearly benefit Korean society, the concept of meritocracy appears not to be a particularly effective tool to achieve it.

Education in the United States is also subject to market forces, albeit in a somewhat different form. The responsibility for funding education is distributed among federal, state, and local authorities in the form of school district budgets that depend on property taxes. Since many families choose where to live based on the quality of local public schools, this leads to disparities in the resources available to different school districts. The same applies to college education, where funding usually comes from a mix of institutional aid, student tuition, and other private sources. According to the U.S. Government Accountability Office, lower-income neighborhoods typically have fewer resources at their disposal, and many students from economically disadvantaged backgrounds find themselves in underfunded schools.[201] This results in considerable inequality in the opportunity to receive a high-quality education within the same country and, in some cases, even within the same city.

The situation is similar in higher education: while financial aid in the United States helps close the gap between what students need to afford college and

[200] Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development, "Education at a Glance 2025: Korea," https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/education-at-a-glance-2025_1a3543e2-en/korea_252c9ed2-en.html.

[201] U.S. Government Accountability Office, "K–12 Education: Student Population Has Significantly Diversified, but Many Schools Remain Divided Along Racial, Ethnic, and Economic Lines," June 16, 2022, https://www.gao.gov/products/gao-22-104737.

the listed prices, the latter still tend to be much higher for low-income families. In public four-year colleges, full-time first-time students from families with an annual income of less than 150% of the poverty level (or $30,000 or less received an average of $13,600) received an average of 15,410 dollars in grants and scholarships but still had to pay 9,700 dollars on average as a net tuition.[202] This is substantially lower than the average tuition paid by more affluent Americans, but it still presents a significantly more considerable portion of the family income.

The two countries examined for this paper reproduce educational inequality through slightly different but still considerable economic disadvantages depending on the student's background. In South Korea, the gap between the educational opportunities of the more and the less prosperous is largely determined by the ability to pay for private education and secure access to more demanding academic courses. In the United States, the same gap is partially explained by the difference between school districts and the overall cost of higher education. Both countries allow for social mobility through education, but in neither is education a guarantee of equal opportunity. As a result, social inequality of outcomes persists with all the economic risks that implies for human capital and productivity.

Demographic and Long-Term Economic Effects

The economic effects of education also extend beyond generations, shaping and shaping the way. Education costs and structures can affect family

[202] National Center for Education Statistics, "Price of Attending an Undergraduate Institution," *Condition of Education*, https://nces.ed.gov/programs/coe/indicator/cua.

formation decisions, and demographic change, in turn, affects school enrollment, public spending, and future labor supply. These connections are particularly relevant in South Korea and the United States, which are both aging and grappling with low fertility rates. Nonetheless, the link between education and demographic change is more immediate in Korea, where the pressure to educate and the costs of education create a more direct financial burden on families.

In South Korea, private education has become an inevitable burden for many parents, and the costs of education can contribute to the perception of children as too great an expenditure. In 2023, some 78.5 percent of primary and secondary school students received private tutoring, at an average monthly cost of 434,000 won per student, or 10 percent of average household disposable income. In addition, 49.2 percent of Korean parents viewed the expenditures on private tutors and education as extremely burdensome, and 27 percent considered education and childcare costs a major factor in the country's low fertility rate.[203] This is not to say that education costs are the sole reason why Korean families have fewer children, as home prices, job precarity, work intensification, and gender inequality also play a role in these decisions. Nonetheless, the financial and competitive pressures related to education make it so that, for many Korean parents, an additional child is an additional great financial burden.

This, in turn, will affect the education systems of the future and the broader economy. The number of children between the ages of five and 14 in Korea

[203] OECD, "Responding to Population Decline," *OECD Economic Surveys: Korea 2024*, 2024, https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/oecd-economic-surveys-korea-2024_c243e16a-en/full-report/responding-to-population-decline_7f6620e6.html.

is expected to drop by 40 percent by 2033.[204] This drop will affect school enrollments and result in fewer teaching positions as the student-to-teacher ratios drop; this, in turn, will create financial pressure on schools, resulting in their closures or consolidations, especially in rural areas. It will also affect the location of schools: As fewer and fewer students will move into rural areas, there will be less of a need for schools there, even as these areas will see the faster shrinkage of their taxable bases. Small classes in principle allow for more personalized learning, but maintaining such a structure might become economically unviable as fewer students enroll in schools, especially in rural areas. Finally, a smaller overall student cohort will eventually translate into fewer workers, as the current children and young people reach working age. These workers will have to support the aging Korean population, creating additional pressure on the future labor force.

While South Korea's demographic challenges are severe, the United States' are more gradual, but still relevant to education and the economy. An aging population and decreasing school enrollments are both projected to occur in the United States, although the overall population loss in the United States occurs more slowly than in South Korea. Some 66 percent of the United States' population was of working age in 2022, but that number is projected to decrease as the population ages. Immigration can affect this, as immigrants are more likely to be of working age than the US-born population, as noted by the Census Bureau, which helps offset the effects of an aging population.[205] Nonetheless, the total public and private school

[204] OECD, "Education at a Glance 2026: Korea," 2026, https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/education-at-a-glance-2026_c0e523a9-en/korea_5e4f6d39-en.html.

[205] U.S. Census Bureau, "By 2060, Less Than 60% of Non-Hispanic White Population and About 65% of Non-Hispanic Multiracial Population Will Be Working Age," July 2, 2024, https://www.census.gov/library/stories/2024/07/population-projections.html.

enrollment in the United States is projected to drop by approximately 8 percent between 2019 and 2030, with enrollments varying significantly across different racial groups.[206] This results in fewer overall students and a different mix of students across regions and schools, which in turn has implications for the future labor force.

Namely, the United States' long-term economic prospects will depend not on the number of students who receive an education, but on whether these students can reach their full potential. A large part of the US workforce is expected to retire soon, which means that, if the United States wishes to maintain its living standards, these workers' capabilities will have to be substituted with the capabilities of the next generation. This will become difficult if school funding, college costs, or the quality of education vary dramatically across different types of schools, limiting the potential of students who attend underfunded schools. Additionally, while immigration adds to the size of the potential workforce, its impact also depends on the ability of the education systems in the United States to equip these new citizens with the skills they need to succeed. Educational inequity has long-lasting demographic effects, as the future workforce will have to be both more diverse and more skilled if the United States wishes to avoid a decline in its living standards.

The long-term economic effects of education are different in both countries, but relevant in either case. In South Korea, the pressures to gain skills through education and the costs of such education combine to make children an unwise financial commitment for many families. These pressures, in turn, will lead to further decreases in school enrollments,

[206] National Center for Education Statistics, "Projections of Education Statistics to 2028: Elementary and Secondary Enrollment," https://nces.ed.gov/programs/PES/section-1.asp.

putting financial strain on schools, public budgets, and future workers who will have to support an aging population. In the United States, the effects of education are more indirect, but nonetheless vital; while the costs of education may not affect the decision to have children, access to quality education and the ability to speak English affect the likelihood that a person will be able to gain the skills needed for the future economy. In both countries, the long-term economic value of education will depend on its ability to maintain public financing, provide opportunities to children from all socio-economic backgrounds, and adapt to a changing population.

Conclusion

Sejin Oh

If you belong to the Korean education system, you're always surrounded by heartbreaking instances where kids tie their self-worth to grades, and how this affects all aspects of life. I saw how kids treated the ones with higher grades better, and especially because I went to a hypercompetitive school, you get a general sense of who's good and who's not very quickly. The ones who struggle are looked down upon by everyone, even themselves. I've seen so many kids go from having a personality that would light up the room to becoming more subdued and losing their confidence. This hyperfocus on grades also led to a lot of conflict, and this was one of the biggest reasons for why I left.

The faulty education system ends up affecting so much more. Low birthrates are largely affected by not wanting to raise your child in this environment and not wanting to pay thousands each month for hagwons. Such a competitive atmosphere overall also leads to toxic cultures in general, where polarization, in politics, gender conflicts, and regions happen. Especially in such a meritocratic society like Korea, lack of result is directly attributed to lack of effort, feeding the vicious cycle further.

I've experienced a spectrum of US-Korean education systems, from a public school in the US to one of the most competitive high schools in Korea to a mix of both in the HAFS international track. On top of this, one of the most interesting conversations I always have with my friends from international high schools and high schools from all over is a comparison of our school systems. Also, I live close to Daechi, which is one of the most competitive neighborhoods and the biggest hub for private academies. I've always recognized that there was a problem with Daechi and the hypercompetitive Korean education system, but while I sort of accepted it in my earlier years, after hearing of so many education systems, I've sparked a hope of reformation for my beloved neighborhood.

This was what ultimately inspired me to write this book. I'm interested in education because I essentially view it as the first great differentiator: it's something everybody goes through, and is one of the biggest indicators of your later socio-economic status. I hope this book can become a first small step in reform. Like with Michael Moore's documentary, Where to Invade Next, comparative education policies can inspire further mutual growth.

In School Life, Twice Lived, my co-author and I examine the American and Korean education systems through historical, political, sociological, and economic perspectives, combining our personal experiences with academic

research and empirical analysis. We begin by tracing the historical development of both systems, examining how political institutions, cultural values, and economic priorities shaped the schools we know today. We then explore students' everyday experiences through surveys and interviews, comparing everything from classroom instruction and assessment to private education and college admissions. Finally, we examine the consequences of these educational differences beyond the classroom, particularly their effects on employment, socioeconomic mobility, inequality, and economic development. Throughout the book, we seek to understand why the differences emerged and what each country might learn from the other more than merely trying to understand how the two systems differ.

Jinseo Park

Having experienced within the Korean, Malaysian, and U.S. educational systems, I have been interested in not only their differences but also in how they might be shaping the societies in which they exist. Attending classes in such places allowed me to recognize how far-reaching the impact of education is: how it informs the way students speak with superiors, respond to failure, regard achievement, compete with peers, and plan for the future. All of these mannerisms and mindsets taken together comprise a culture. For example, although an exam-focused system produces disciplined and studious students, it also makes them susceptible to the fear of failure. While

an interactive and free system prides itself on critical thinking and self-expression, it may produce inconsistencies in the quality of education based on geographic and financial accessibility.

This link between education and society is what I hoped to explore through my research for this book. Not only does the Korean system produce high-performing students and graduates but also imposes high expectations on parents and affects the financial situation of many households. Although the American system may be less rigorous and consistent, it can lead to the devaluation of education and the depreciation of the quality of services and goods due to the lack of competitive edge among graduates. More systematically, the competencies which students learn at school influence the economy in terms of productivity, innovation, and demographical shifts.

In addition, my cross-comparison of the two systems showed that neither of them is perfect, and that both have had to make sacrifices in order to arrive at their current states. Korea's structured and consistent education system, which emphasizes high achievement since early ages, has led the country to be one of the most literate and educated in the world. Yet, this same system puts an unreasonably high burden on students and utilizes the private education system for profit. The American system, in contrast, gives students more options, more say in the matters of education, more opportunities to engage in non-academic extracurricular activities and to

represent their achievements outside of the classroom, yet it is inconsistent and leaves many students underserved.

The ideal education system therefore combines the best parts of the ones found in Korea or the U.S., and overcomes their shortcomings by providing a more personalized and accessible path to a competitive and consistent level of educational attainment. It would have rigorous academic standards, as well as a wide range of options for students who wish to pursue different branches of knowledge. It would also give students and teachers more freedom by removing the emphasis on grades and allowing students to take charge of their own learning. Finally, it would give students the opportunity not only to learn but also to grow as individuals, find their passion, and express it through art, research, and interaction with like-minded people. The purpose of such a system would not be to make students better workers, but rather to train them to be better people.

It is my hope that this book serves as a reminder that there is not one perfect system of education. By looking carefully at the ways in which education systems of Korea and the U.S. have shaped the people and the societies in which they are located, we can understand what they do right and where they might need improvement. Through the comparison and contrast of these two educational systems, I hope to have shown the reader why one

system might be better than the other in a certain area, or how they might combine their parts to form an even better system.

Appendix

Questionnaire on Students' Experiences in Korean and U.S. Schools (translated from Korean)

Question Number	Questions	Response Type
1	What type of school have you primarily attended?	☐ General high school ☐ Foreign language high school ☐ International high school ☐ Science/Gifted high school ☐ Autonomous private high school ☐ Arts high school/sports high school ☐ Vocational/Meister high school ☐ International School ☐ Other
2	To what extent are you able to choose your own courses?	☐ Almost no choice (0 courses/sem.) ☐ Limited choice (1-2 courses/sem.) ☐ Moderate choice (3-4 courses/sem.) ☐ Considerable choice (5-6 courses/sem.)

		☐ Complete choice (all courses)
3	How often do discussions, presentations, experiments, or project-based activities take place in class?	☐ Never ☐ Rarely ☐ Sometimes ☐ Often ☐ In almost every class
4	How comfortable are you asking questions during class?	☐ Very comfortable ☐ Somewhat comfortable ☐ Neutral ☐ Somewhat uncomfortable ☐ Very uncomfortable
5	How many hours per week do you spend on private education or private tutoring?	☐ None ☐ Fewer than 3 hours ☐ 3 to fewer than 6 hours ☐ 6 to fewer than 10 hours ☐ 10 hours or more
6	If you were to stop receiving private education, what changes do you think would occur in your schoolwork or college admissions preparation?	☐ Almost no effect ☐ Somewhat disadvantaged ☐ Significantly disadvantaged ☐ It would actually improve ☐ I do not currently receive private education
7	To what extent do you feel that you need to study	☐ Not necessary at all ☐ Not very necessary

	course material in advance in order to keep up with school classes?	☐ Somewhat necessary ☐ Very necessary ☐ Absolutely necessary
8	How much free time do you have on weekdays without studying or scheduled activities? (Excluding sleep)	☐ Almost none ☐ Fewer than 1 hour ☐ 1 to fewer than 2 hours ☐ 2 to fewer than 3 hours ☐ 3 hours or more
9	What is your current level of academic stress?	Scale of 1-10 (1: None at all, 10: Extremely severe)
10	Where does the pressure related to academics mainly come from? (Select up to two)	☐ My own expectations ☐ Parents or family ☐ Teachers or school ☐ Friends or other schools ☐ The general climate of Korean society ☐ I do not experience significant pressure
11	Which area of Korean high school education do you currently feel is most in need of improvement?	☐ Excessive academic workload ☐ Test- and grade-centered education ☐ Inequality of opportunity based on school, region, or family background

		☐ Students' limited ability to choose courses ☐ Heavy reliance on private education ☐ Excessive competition among students ☐ Insufficient preparation for careers and practical life ☐ I do not perceive any major problems
12	If there are any school-life experiences or opinions that were not addressed in the survey, please write them freely.	Open-ended

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